DOUBLE ISSUE

MARCH 14 / MARCH 21, 2022

WOMEN OF THE YEAR

12 LEADERS WORKING TOWARD A MORE EQUAL WORLD

HUMAN-RIGHTS LAWYER

AMAL CLOONEY

BY MARIA RESSA

ALLYSON FELIX
AMANDA GORMAN
ZAHRA JOYA
KACEY MUSGRAVES
KERRY WASHINGTON
+ MORE

TIME Magazine

[March 14th, 2022]

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How We Chose the 2022 Women of the Year

Naina Bajekal is executive editor and international editor at TIME, where she oversees World and Technology coverage. She is the editor of the TIME100 AI and the co-editor of TIME's Women of the Year list.

Lucy Feldman is a senior editor at TIME, where she oversees coverage of books and authors. She is co-editor of TIME's Women of the Year franchise and a member of the TIME100 editorial team.

In March 2020, just weeks before the world closed down with the arrival of COVID-19, TIME published a project highlighting 100 influential women, one per year starting in 1920. This was our way of correcting the record, addressing the legacy of a publication long known for its Man of the Year franchise, which only became Person of the Year in 1999. The response to that project was overwhelming, and it crystallized our desire to find more ways to highlight the impact that women have on the world.

The pandemic underscored the ways in which broken systems hurt women, from rising domestic violence to disproportionate job losses. When we sat down last fall to conceive a version of this project that could become an ongoing tradition, we chose to spotlight leaders who are working to create a better future for women everywhere. Our 2022 Women of the Year list features 12 individuals who have reached across communities, generations, and borders to fight for a more inclusive and equitable world.

“You have to have dogged determination,” human-rights lawyer and Women of the Year honoree Amal Clooney said in a rare interview, given to Nobel Peace Prize–winning journalist Maria Ressa, who was herself named a Person of the Year in 2018. “You’re coming up against people whose power and existence depends on them continuing to commit serious abuses, and they’re not going to give up. So we definitely can’t give up on our side.”

[video id=BOBsUGMk autostart="viewable"]

Clooney’s words took on searing prescience when, a week before this project was set to launch, Russian President Vladimir Putin ordered forces to invade Ukraine. Hundreds of thousands of people have fled the country—mostly women and children, with fighting-age men summoned to fight.

Images from the borders have called to mind another humanitarian crisis that has defined the past year. When the Taliban returned to power in Afghanistan, Zahra Joya, the founder of Rukhshana Media and one of the country’s few female journalists, was evacuated to London. But she and her team of female reporters inside Afghanistan and abroad continue to report on the issues affecting Afghan women. “We don’t do simple journalism these days,” Joya, one of this year’s honorees, told TIME contributing editor Angelina Jolie. “We are trying to write for our freedom.”

Some of the women on our list have stepped into the spotlight with new solutions. Software engineer Tracy Chou experienced relentless abuse online, and created an app to combat it. Jennie Joseph, a British midwife based in Florida, is fighting to end the Black maternal mortality crisis by training one midwife at a time.

Others are using the power they already have to lift up the less empowered. After the 2016 election, actor and producer Kerry Washington committed to leveraging her celebrity to fuel her political activism. “The most effective use of my microphone,” Washington said, “is handing it to women and marginalized people.”

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Leading with empathy and compassion was a thread that ran through the honorees’ stories. Inaugural poet Amanda Gorman emphasized her appreciation for leadership qualities often seen as “feminine.” And singer-songwriter Kacey Musgraves spoke about finding the courage to write honest music: “It always makes it easier to put vulnerable thoughts out there when you know they’re going to be met with connection.”

On March 8, International Women’s Day, we’ll convene the honorees at a TIME Women of the Year gala in Los Angeles. We can’t wait to be in the room with these incredible women, and to hear them connect over their ideas. Allyson Felix said it best: “When you speak your truth, things happen. You draw power from one another.”

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How Volodymyr Zelensky Defended Ukraine and United the World

Simon Shuster is a senior correspondent at TIME. He covers international affairs, with a focus on Russia and Ukraine. For his first book, *The Showman*, he reported inside the Ukrainian President's compound in Kyiv as the Russian invasion unfolded.

The President wanted to get to the trenches. He'd already walked for half an hour in his helmet through the mud, surrounded by generals and guards, and he insisted they continue. On the far side of some sagging power lines, the group could see the start of the Russian positions, well within reach of the snipers who had killed three Ukrainian soldiers two weeks before. But Volodymyr Zelensky refused to stop.

"Our guys are over there, right?" the commander in chief asked one of his generals, who was advising the group to turn back. "They'll hear I came all this way and didn't come to see them. They'll be upset." Then Zelensky tossed a glance in my direction, spun around, and continued hiking through the brush.

The gesture made me wonder: Was this an act? We'd met for interviews before, the first time backstage at Zelensky's comedy show in the spring of 2019, during his moonshot campaign for Ukraine's presidency. We met again that winter in Kyiv's presidential headquarters, which he described at the time, only half joking, as a gilded fortress he wanted to escape. But this trip to the front lines last April was the first time I'd seen him with his troops—the former actor playing the part of the generalissimo. It was not entirely convincing.

The danger, though, was very real. By the time Zelensky came to power, Ukraine had been at war with Russia for more than five years. The death toll had topped 13,000, with almost nightly

shooting or shelling across the front lines, a jagged tear between the once fraternal nations. No one knew at the time that the war would soon become incalculably worse. But during our trip to the front, Zelensky was aware the Russian troops were already massing by the tens of thousands on the other side of the border.

“They want us to be afraid,” he told me at the end of the trip, as we flew back to Kyiv on the presidential plane. “They want the West to be frightened of the strength and power of Russia. There’s no big secret here.” Zelensky understood that showing his fear would play into Russia’s hands, though he admitted that the threat of an invasion scared him. “What’s frightening is that their intentions may not end” with a show of force at the border, he told me. “There could be a broader military plan.”

From the Archives: *TIME’s April 2021 Interview With Volodymyr Zelensky on Russia*

About 10 months later, in the early morning hours of Feb. 24, Russia put that plan into effect. Vladimir Putin ordered his troops to “de-Nazify” Ukraine, his chosen term for ousting the first Jewish President in its history and installing a regime loyal to Russia in his place. The invasion thrust Zelensky into a different role, one that at first seemed ill-suited to his character. His friends and advisers

have often told me that Zelensky has thin skin. He suffers from the actor's malady: an abiding need to be liked and applauded. "We try not to let him look at Facebook," one adviser told me, because critical comments from strangers were liable to depress him.

But as the Russian bombs began to fall on Ukrainian cities and troops moved to surround the capital, the President underwent a transformation. Before our eyes he came to embody a struggle that most Western statesmen had long forgotten how to fight, the one that is sometimes required to keep tyranny from killing off democracy. Zelensky not only rallied his own people to defend their nation, inspiring them to toss petrol bombs at Russian military vehicles and stand in the way of tanks. He also galvanized the world's democracies in ways that seemed unthinkable just a week before.

The change was not instantaneous. Western leaders were still divided two days after the invasion, when they met to agree on a package of sanctions to punish Russia for its attack. Germany, Hungary, and Italy initially wanted to water down these measures. Then Zelensky dialed in to their meeting. Calm but determined, his pale face covered in stubble, he told the leaders of the free world that this might be the last time they would see him alive. "The enemy has marked me as target No. 1," he said in a video statement shortly after the call. "My family is target No. 2."

Yet Zelensky decided to stay in his capital, an act of courage that has already altered the course of history. It roused the U.S. and its allies to impose unprecedented penalties against Russia, crashing the ruble and unplugging much of its economy from the rest of the world. Germany decided to pour more than $100 billion into its military, casting aside a postwar tradition of pacifism that has long frustrated allies. Switzerland broke from its tradition of neutrality to support sanctions. The E.U. agreed to put Ukraine on a path to membership, shedding decades of internal resistance.

On the sixth day of the invasion, Zelensky delivered a speech via video link to the European Parliament. “Do prove that you are with us,” he implored through an interpreter, who seemed to choke back tears while translating the President’s words. “Do prove that you will not let us go. Do prove that you indeed are Europeans, and then life will win over death, and light will win over darkness.” As one observer noted, it was as if Charlie Chaplin had morphed into Winston Churchill.

Zelensky now spends his days underground, in bunkers and basements, emerging every now and then to raise the nation’s spirits, often on social media. In one video message, he shares a meal with a few of his troops: bread with salami, sprats, and instant coffee. The people who surround him are mostly old friends, the ones who followed him through the world of show business, into the presidency, and now to war. “No one is here by accident,” his chief of staff, Andriy Yermak, wrote to me from the bunker on the seventh day of the invasion.

Born in 1978, the future President grew up in a working-class Jewish family in the city of Kryvyi Rih (“Crooked Horn”), in the shadow of Ukraine’s biggest steel mill. Like many in that part of the country, his parents spoke Russian at home. Like nearly all Jews in Ukraine, the family had suffered tremendously during World WarII. Zelensky’s grandfather, who commanded an artillery

platoon in the Red Army, lost his father and three of his brothers in the Holocaust.

After the Soviet Union fell apart in 1991, Zelensky's hometown became what he called a "city of bandits," its economy in steep decline. To stay off the streets, he joined a sketch-comedy troupe at 17, performing with his friends around Ukraine and later in Russia. The troupe went on to form a production company called Kvartal 95 (District 95), after the neighborhood where they grew up. "It was a rough place, the kind that makes you desperate to escape," says Vadim Pereverzev, Zelensky's old friend and business partner. "That was our main motivation."

The offices of Kvartal 95 now occupy the top three floors of a high-rise near the center of Kyiv, with panoramic views over the city. Its walls are covered in posters for the movies they produced, mostly romantic comedies with the future President in the starring roles. Zelensky also lent his raspy voice to the animated bear in the Ukrainian version of Paddington. He worked on the Ukrainian version of Dancing With the Stars, both as a contestant (he won) and a producer.

His biggest hit was a sitcom called Servant of the People, which first aired in 2015. The show was based on a wacky premise: a high school history teacher, played by Zelensky, uncorks an epic rant against corruption, which one of his students films and posts on YouTube. The clip goes viral on the eve of an election, prompting voters to install the teacher as the nation's President in a rebuke to the amoral elites.

The show was a sensation in both Russia and Ukraine, and in 2019 it became Zelensky's springboard into politics. In a video posted on YouTube that New Year's Eve, he stood next to a Christmas tree and announced his intention to run for Ukraine's highest office. Voters flocked to his campaign, which was hardly traditional: Zelensky did not take part in debates or publish an electoral platform. Instead he continued touring with his comedy show, a mix of vaudeville and political satire that was not always in the best of taste. (One sketch had Zelensky pretend to play a Jewish folk song on the piano with his penis.) When the act premiered in Kyiv during the presidential race, the city's biggest concert hall was filled to capacity, despite ticket prices that ran about as high as the average Ukrainian monthly pension. Members of the troupe partied backstage, wondering what Cabinet positions they might get if Zelensky won. "I think I'd make a pretty good Defense Minister," said one comedian, Alexander Pikalov, after pouring me a shot of whiskey in a plastic cup.

In his dressing room after the show, Zelensky had little interest in discussing politics or foreign affairs. The closest he came was this promise: "We'll figure it out." His production company had just wrapped the third season of Servant of the People, in which Zelensky's character saves Ukraine from ruin. It appeared on Netflix a few days before the election, giving voters enough time to

binge the season before heading to the polls. “There’s no way the others can compete with that,” Zelensky told me with a smile in his dressing room.

He was right. Nearly three-quarters of the electorate cast their ballots for him in the final round of voting. His campaign swept virtually every region of the country, including those that tend to lean toward Russia. That May, Zelensky’s new political party, which he had named after his sitcom, took a majority in parliament, becoming the first in Ukraine’s history to control both the legislature and the executive branch.

Zelensky’s first priority as President was to bring peace with Russia. But he faced an obstacle in Ukraine’s most important ally. Two months into his tenure, the U.S. froze aid to Ukraine worth nearly $400 million, most of it meant to shore up the nation’s military. U.S. President Donald Trump wanted the Ukrainians to legitimize his claims of corruption against Joe Biden, and he was using the military aid as leverage. In a phone call in July 2019, Trump asked Zelensky to “do us a favor” by announcing investigations into those bogus claims.

The blackmail attempt, which led to Trump's first impeachment in the House of Representatives, dented Zelensky's faith in Ukraine's foreign partners. "I don't trust anyone at all," he said when we met in his office that December. A few days later, he was due to meet Putin for their first round of peace negotiations. His expectations were low, but he was intent on doing whatever it took to avoid a broader war. The eastern regions Russia occupied in 2014, he said, were not worth the lives of Ukrainian soldiers. "I cannot send them there," he told me. "How? How many of them will die? Hundreds of thousands, and then an all-out war will start, an all-out war in Ukraine, and then across Europe."

The talks with Putin went nowhere. Russia refused to cede control of the breakaway regions in east Ukraine, and the government in Kyiv refused to grant those regions the autonomy Moscow demanded. Soon the COVID-19 pandemic was raging, and Zelensky could not secure vaccine supplies from his allies in the West. Nor would he accept an offer from Putin to provide Ukraine with Russian-made vaccines, which Kyiv saw as a weapon in Moscow's information war. Many voters felt differently. By the end of 2020, public support for Zelensky dropped as low as 20% in some surveys, down from over 70% a year earlier.

Read More: *Putin Wants Revenge Not Just on Ukraine But on the U.S. and Its Allies*

The Ukrainian government then turned its focus to political skirmishes, going after pro-Russian politicians and other domestic opponents. The first big target of the crackdown was Putin's close friend Viktor Medvedchuk, who chairs the biggest opposition party in the Ukrainian parliament. The state seized the assets of Medvedchuk's family and later placed him under house arrest. Even some of Zelensky's closest allies were dismayed at the decision. "It certainly raises questions about the rule of law," Dmytro Razumkov, who had led Zelensky's presidential campaign, told me in October, hours before he was ousted as speaker of the parliament.

Putin was furious over the crackdown against his friend Medvedchuk, calling it an "obvious purge of the political field." He responded by sending thousands of Russian troops to the border for a series of "large-scale exercises" that went on for most of 2021. Shelling and sniper fire increased along the front lines. The U.S. began to warn of a rapid escalation, even an invasion.

Through it all, Zelensky tried to project a sense of calm. On our visit to the front lines in early April, he spent nearly an hour talking to the troops inside a system of trenches they had nicknamed Vietnam—a nod to the mud and morass of a war they had seen in the movies. General Ruslan Khomchak, then the top commander of Ukraine's armed forces, took the President to the spot where three of his soldiers had been killed in an ambush two weeks earlier. "There was no tactical reason to attack that post," Khomchak said. "They just shot those boys in cold blood."

To my surprise, Zelensky did not promise to avenge them. Instead he questioned the wisdom of sacrificing soldiers in defense of these muddy dugouts. Ukraine had seized that bit of ground in a violent push in 2018, the year before Zelensky was elected. "For some,

that meant we were the tough guys," he told me before we headed back toward the armored cars. "For others it meant their sons would not be coming home." The President had no intention of making such trades again. The lives of his soldiers, he said, were more valuable to him than any scraps of contested terrain.

His foil in the Kremlin clearly disagreed. By early winter, the number of Russian troops on Ukraine's borders topped 70,000. Around Halloween, the warnings from the U.S. government began to grow more dire. At meetings in Kyiv and Washington, U.S. intelligence officials and diplomats tried to convince Zelensky's team that a Russian invasion was imminent. "They put the chances at 80%," says one foreign policy adviser to Zelensky, who received these briefings last fall. The Americans backed up their estimates, the adviser says, with satellite imagery of Russian hardware arrayed at the border, as well as intercepted communications that suggested Russia was preparing to invade.

But Zelensky and his inner circle did not believe an invasion was at hand. Ukrainian border guards told him the chances of a full-scale attack were not much higher than they had been since the war started in 2014. "We're talking about a black-swan event," says Iuliia Mendel, a communications adviser to Zelensky. "Nobody could believe it was going to happen."

Read More: *The Untold Story of the Ukraine Crisis*

In the early morning of Feb. 24, both Putin and Zelensky appeared on TV in their respective countries to deliver their final speeches before the invasion commenced. The contrast between them could not have been starker. Putin's address dripped with menace, and his claims against Ukraine were detached from reality. He said he had ordered a "special military operation" aimed at the "demilitarization and de-Nazification" of the entire country. It was a pledge, in effect, to oust the government of a sovereign nation and destroy the armed forces of Russia's largest neighbor to the

west. Putin also issued a chilling threat to any “outside forces” that might come to Ukraine’s defense: “It will lead to consequences of the sort that you have not faced ever in your history.”

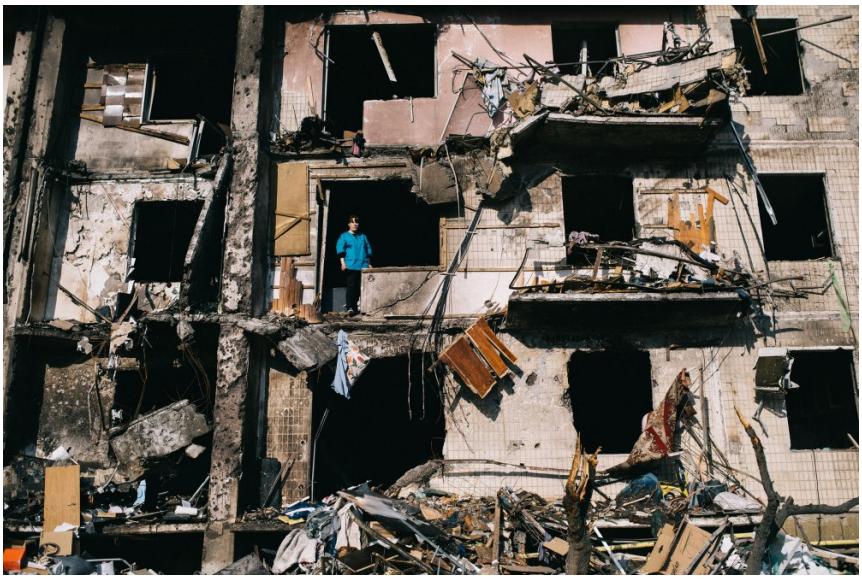
In his own address, Zelensky chose to speak directly to the Russian people. He told them he had tried to reach Putin that day in a final effort to avert the invasion, but the Kremlin had ignored him. Then he tried to counteract the propaganda coming from Russian state TV. “You are told that these flames will bring freedom to Ukraine. But the people of Ukraine are already free,” he said. “In attacking us, you will see our faces, not our backs.”

The Russian assault began that morning with a barrage of rockets lobbed at cities across Ukraine. Troops poured over the border from multiple directions, making a push toward Kyiv from the north in an attempt to overrun the capital. Zelensky holed up in the presidential headquarters with his team of close advisers. His chief of staff, Yermak, remembers that as a moment of clarity. “When you realize that, despite all your efforts, the scariest thing of all has happened, then everything becomes extremely sharp and clear,” he wrote to me. “We are here, they are there. They attacked us. We are defending. Truth is on our side.”

It gave Ukraine a clear advantage in the information war, where Zelensky’s stagecraft turned into a powerful weapon. As Russia spread lies about neo-Nazis using children in Ukraine as human shields, Zelensky countered with a barrage of posts on social media, letting his people hear the earnest, grainy voice they had come to know from his movies. He seemed to be near them, and he was: Zelensky had refused an offer from the U.S. to evacuate him to safer ground. “I need ammunition,” he told the Americans. “Not a ride.”

The President did not even retreat from the government quarter in Kyiv’s center. Nor did he wear a bulletproof vest. Photos and

videos showed him in a T-shirt as he led his besieged nation from some of the same familiar rooms, with their indigo carpets and heavy chandeliers, where I had met him and his staff at the start of his tenure. Only now the floors were heaped with sandbags and soldiers stood around, forming a weak defense against the Russian bombs that fell nearby.



Images of devastation reached Zelensky's team from across the country: dozens of fatalities, including children, as artillery pounded residential neighborhoods; a missile striking the TV tower in Kyiv; another one landing on the central square of Kharkiv in the east. Yet for every report of a Russian barrage, there was news of Ukrainians standing their ground, destroying columns of armored Russian vehicles, capturing tanks and prisoners of war. It soon became clear to military experts that Putin had misjudged both the will and the ability of Ukrainians to resist. U.S. intelligence assesses that morale is sagging among the Russian soldiers on the ground, according to a senior U.S. defense official.

On the fourth day of the invasion, Zelensky sent a few of his comrades to an initial round of peace talks with Putin's men. They agreed only to continue talking, even though the Kremlin showed no sign of dropping its demands. As aid poured into Ukraine from the West—including shoulder-fired rockets that could take out

Russian tanks and aircraft—Putin ordered his generals to put Russia's nuclear forces on high alert.

On the last day of February, Zelensky appeared before a camera in the government compound to sign a formal application to join the E.U. "Our goal is to be together with all Europeans and, most importantly, to be on an equal footing," he said. "I'm sure it's fair. I'm sure it's possible." All of a sudden, after nearly two decades of frustrating talks with E.U. leaders, Ukraine appeared to be within reach of joining the bloc. The president of the European Commission, Ursula von der Leyen, told reporters the same day that Ukraine is "one of us and we want them in the European Union."

Toward the end of the first week of all-out war, a 40-mile column of Russian military hardware began to form a noose around Kyiv. Yet Zelensky's advisers assured me that spirits remained high. "We all get what's at stake," Yermak, his chief of staff, wrote me. "Our freedom. The very existence of our state. So we're working flat out, beyond the limits of our strength." Apart from commanding his military forces, the President's days were packed with phone calls of support from around the world: the Prime Ministers of Japan, Norway, Israel, and India; the Presidents of Poland, France, and the

U.S.; the King and Queen of the Netherlands; the Orthodox Patriarch in Istanbul; even the Pope.

With every new promise of aid and prayer for safekeeping, Ukraine and its leader seemed to transcend their roles as victims of aggression. They became examples of the kind of fortitude that all of us hope we can muster when called. There is no faking that kind of courage, and no way to tell whether we have it until the time we need it most. For Zelensky, that moment may have come on Feb. 25, the second night of the invasion. He walked outside his office into the winter air, surrounded by his closest aides, and filmed a simple message on his phone: “We are all here.”

—With reporting by Alejandro de la Garza, W.J. Hennigan, Nik Popli, and Simmone Shah

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How Putin Is Losing at His Own Disinformation Game in Ukraine

Vera Bergengruen is a senior correspondent at TIME, based in the Washington, D.C. bureau. She covers the overlap of national security, politics, and technology. Her work at TIME has won the Society of Professional Journalists' Sigma Delta Chi Award and a New York Press Club Award.

As Russian troops closed in on Kyiv and battered the Ukrainian capital with missile strikes on Friday, rumors spread by Russian state media said that President Volodymyr Zelensky had fled the country.

That evening, as he has been doing for weeks, Zelensky sought to debunk the Russian disinformation narrative directly. In a defiant video posted on social media, he filmed himself by the Bankova, Ukraine’s equivalent to the White House, flanked by the prime minister and other top officials. “We’re all here. We are in Kyiv. We defend Ukraine,” he said. “Our military are here, our citizens and society are here. We are all here defending our independence, our state, and this is how it’s going to be.”

Amid the Russian invasion of their country, the Ukrainian government has treated the information battlefield as a real front line. In Ukrainian, English and Russian, top officials have relentlessly put out their own information on social media, provided regular updates, shot down rumors, and warned of what they say are new false Russian narratives before they can fully take off.

Citing intelligence, Ukraine's foreign minister Dmytro Kuleba on Friday warned that Russia was planning "a massive false flag operation" to accuse Ukraine of human rights abuses. "Don't trust fakes," he tweeted. "Ukraine defends its land in a just and defensive war. Unlike Russia, we don't target kindergartens and civilians." The Defense Ministry has similarly tried to get ahead of rumors by releasing frequent updates on its operations.

These efforts to hamstring the Kremlin's disinformation campaigns come as U.S. officials warn that Russia is ramping up efforts to target Ukrainian soldiers in order to "discourage them and induce surrender through disinformation" as Kyiv braces for attack. "Our information indicates Russia is creating a disinformation campaign by publicizing false reports about the widespread surrender of Ukrainian troops," a U.S. official told TIME in a statement on Friday, adding that the intelligence also "indicates that Russia plans to threaten killing the family members of Ukrainian soldiers if they do not surrender."

Russia, which has a long history of using this type of hybrid warfare to take a psychological toll, used a familiar playbook to sow confusion and doubt in the days before the invasion. These included disinformation campaigns mean to stir panic: in one case, Ukrainians received text messages on their phones alerting them that ATMs had stopped working, false claims that were quickly dispelled by Ukraine's Cyber Police force.

This recalled a similar effort in 2014 when a mass text campaign targeted Ukrainian troops fighting pro-Russian separatists in the eastern part of the country with messages like “Leave and you will live,” “Nobody needs your kids to become orphans,” and “Ukrainian soldiers, they’ll find your bodies when the snow melts.” They were made to look like they were coming from fellow troops, with some claiming that their commanders had betrayed them, with the clear aim of intimidating and sapping morale.

This time around, encrypted messaging chats, which are decentralized and less constrained than social media platforms, have taken on a bigger role. Pro-Russian propaganda has especially been pushed out on Telegram channels, with much of it quickly showing up in a range of English-language rightwing groups. “Russian troops surrounded Kiev. Zelensky may have fled. Russia is fighting not against the Ukrainian peple and army but against Nazi battalions and foreign mercenaries,” read a message that was forwarded in dozens of U.S. right-wing Telegram channels on Friday.

“It’s incredible to watch modern-day information warfare evolving in real time,” says Cindy Otis, a disinformation researcher and former CIA analyst. It’s too early to tell how effectively the Ukrainian efforts to debunk Russian disinformation narratives are working, she says, noting that their success will depend on whether they’re breaking through to their intended audience.

The disinformation battle has been front and center to the White House’s own approach to the conflict from the beginning. Its unprecedented move to publicly release declassified intelligence about Russia’s plans frustrated the Kremlin’s attempts to establish an effective pre-fabricated narrative to invade Ukraine. “We shared declassified evidence about Russia’s plans and false pretext so that there could be no confusion or cover-up about what Putin’s doing,” Biden said on Thursday. “Putin is the aggressor. Putin chose this war.”

The disinformation war has now moved well past that initial stage, but continues apace. With Putin explicitly demanding regime change in Ukraine, calling on the country's military to "take power into your own hands" and overthrow the government, the focus has shifted to tactical disinformation, says Otis. This includes "disinformation at the battlefield level aimed at intimidation and demoralizing the Ukrainian military and civilian population," she tells TIME. "So false narratives about Ukrainian troops giving up, commanders abandoning their troops, claims of successes that didn't actually occur."

While Russia has honed this disinformation environment for decades, there are signs that there may be long-term consequences. On Thursday, Poland announced that it would ban the Russia Today network, following a similar move by Germany the previous week. French lawmakers have asked for RT's license in the country to be revoked. Several other countries have imposed sanctions on the network's editor-in-chief.

In the short term, the fight to shape perceptions of the fast-moving conflict seems more evenly matched than that being fought with military hardware, as compelling examples of resistance to the Russian invasion have galvanized sympathy and support for Ukraine. In one video that went viral in the first hours of the conflict, a Ukrainian woman berates a Russian soldier and tells him to put sunflower seeds in his pocket "so at least sunflowers will grow when you all lie down here."

Sunflowers, a translation of the viral video informs, are the Ukrainian national flower.

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Pediatricians Who Serve Trans Youth Face Increasing Harassment. Lifesaving Care Could Be on the Line

Dr. Gina Sequeira first saw the protesters on a bright clear morning last September. A co-director of Seattle Children's Gender Clinic who provides gender-affirming care to young people, Sequeira had confronted ignorance about her medical specialty in the past. But nothing had prepared her to see people outside her office, waving signs and handing out flyers warning of the "dangers" of the work she does.

"That was really, really hard for us as a clinic," she says. "And I think it was really hard for the hospital's patients and families who witnessed it." Just a month later, protesters showed up again.

Hers wasn't the only clinic having a hard time in 2021. The LGBTQ advocacy group Human Rights Campaign has calculated that, last year, conservative lawmakers introduced over 130 anti-trans bills into state legislatures—including 35 that explicitly limited the ability of trans and gender-expansive youth to access gender-affirming care, a term that refers to holistic psychological

and medical care that affirms a person's gender identity. As of Feb. 11, the ACLU has tracked similar bills in at least 17 state legislatures this year.

Only a small group of pediatricians provide such care in the U.S., and, in this political context, those who do are often finding themselves at the receiving end of growing harassment—even as research confirms the potentially life-saving nature of the work they do. Demonstrators have organized protests like the ones at Sequeira's clinic at other sites across the country; in Ohio, billboards have been rented spreading disinformation about affirming care—including one near a children's hospital. Pediatricians tell TIME they have received threatening mail, have been impersonated online and have feared for their safety. And they worry such harassment campaigns could have a devastating impact on the ability of young people to access crucial medical care.

Roughly a month before the September protest, Sequeira had received an unmarked letter in the mail that gave her pause. She'd worried about the risk of anthrax, she tells TIME; of someone trying to hurt her. Eventually she gingerly opened the envelope. Inside, she found printed posters decrying gender-affirming care for children. "No child is born in the wrong body!" one read. "Who profits from this crime?"

"I was taken aback, and really kind of fearful," Sequeira recalls. She'd seen colleagues who provided abortion receive similar abuse. But she never thought her work could become nearly as controversial. "It really made me wonder what the future of our work looks like," she says. "Is that the path we're going down?"

Gender-affirming care can support youth experiencing gender dysphoria, which is often described as the discomfort or distress that might occur when a person's gender identity is inconsistent with the sex they were assigned at birth, per the Mayo Clinic. In gender-affirming care models, according to the American Academy of Pediatrics (AAP), "pediatric providers offer developmentally appropriate care that is oriented toward understanding and appreciating the youth's gender experience." That includes conveying the message that variations in gender identity and expression are a normal aspect of human diversity, and that, if a mental health issue does exist, it "most often stems from stigma and negative experiences rather than being intrinsic to the child."

In young children, gender dysphoria can be treated with non-medical social and behavioral interventions, which can include allowing a child to present themselves in alignment with their gender identity by changing the way they dress, for example, or changing their given name and pronouns, explains Dr. Morissa Ladinsky, a pediatrician at the University of Alabama at Birmingham who specializes in affirming care.

Read more: *Gender-Affirming Hormone Therapy for LGBTQ Youth Can Help Save Lives, Study Finds*

After puberty has begun, a child experiencing gender dysphoria may also begin receiving gonadotropin-releasing hormone (GnRH) analogues—known by the term “puberty blockers.” They are “simply a pause button,” says Ladinsky, to stop the continued development of a puberty incongruent with a child’s gender identity. Used at this stage, blockers are reversible, says Ladinsky, and have been used safely for over 30 years in other pediatric conditions like central precocious puberty, which causes children to enter the developmental stage too early. Puberty blockers can help “reduce distress that may occur with the development of secondary sexual characteristics” and reduce the need for surgery in the future by holding off physical changes like an Adams apple or breast growth, according to the AAP.

When they get older, some adolescents will begin taking gender-affirming hormones, such as testosterone or estradiol. While there is some debate within the medical community on when any given young person should start hormones, the intervention has proven pivotal to the treatment of dysphoria in many adolescents. It is rare for a person under 18 to undergo any type of surgical intervention, but some may decide to pursue “top surgery”—reconstructive surgery to change the appearance of one’s chest—while they are still teenagers.

An emerging body of research has found that affirming care models can result in young people having fewer mental health concerns. As with all medical care, treatment decisions are nuanced, and, because of the age of the patients, are driven by conversations between the young person, their family and their doctor. Trans and gender expansive children cannot receive affirming medical treatment without their parent’s or guardian’s consent in the U.S. healthcare system.

Yet much of the criticism surrounding gender-affirming care operates from the misperception that young children are receiving rushed, unsupervised, irreversible treatments. In violent, visceral

terms, best-selling authors, right-wing commentators, conservative social-media stars, and other influential figures have made such arguments, stirring a moral panic that has grown in recent years. The Williams Institute at UCLA estimated in April 2021 that 45,100 trans youth were at risk of losing medical care if all the bills then under consideration that intended to restrict or ban gender-affirming care were implemented into law. In the same month, Arkansas went so far as to ban pediatricians from not only providing gender-affirming care, but even providing a referral to patients. (The law is currently blocked by a federal judge.) In August, Texas Gov. Greg Abbott suggested that providing affirming care to adolescents equates to child abuse.

Mis- and disinformation about trans people has also gained airtime in conservative media, especially online. A Nov. 9 report from Media Matters found that 77% of the top-performing trans-related Facebook posts between Oct. 2020 and Sept. 2021 were on right-leaning pages, as were nearly two-thirds of all the interactions on posts about trans issues.

“There’s nothing grassroots about this at all,” argues Imara Jones, journalist and founder of TransLash Media, whose podcast the Anti-Trans Hate Machine has documented the rapid rise of anti-trans legislation in recent years. “This is a highly organized movement that is targeting trans people and trans rights.”’

Jones traces the proliferation of anti-trans bills to an umbrella organization of over 60 right-wing groups called Promise to America’s Children, which lists on its website “leading national partners” including Family Policy Alliance (the lobbying arm of longtime anti-LGBTQ group Focus on the Family), Alliance Defending Freedom (which the Southern Poverty Law Center has defined as an anti-LGBTQ hate group), and conservative think tank The Heritage Foundation. She adds that the anti-LGBTQ group Family Research Council has actively promoted anti-trans bills.

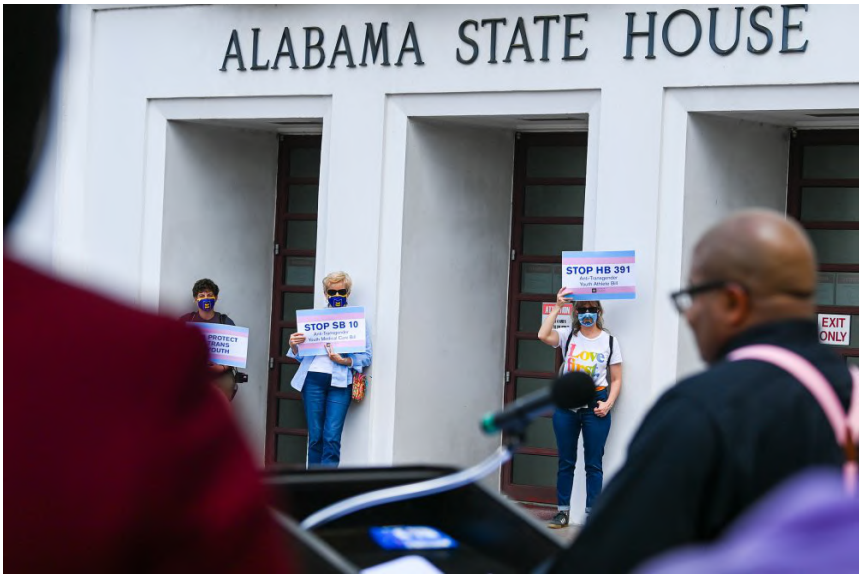
Promise to America's Children's website includes model legislation for policymakers titled the "Protecting Children from Experimentation Act," which aims to criminalize gender-affirming treatment for young people. A version of the bill was introduced in Congress in 2021, though it did not advance.

Leading medical organizations have decried such legislative bans. "[We] strongly oppose any effort to criminalize or penalize physicians for providing necessary care for their patients," read a April 2021 joint press statement from AAP, the American Academy of Family Physicians, the American College of Physicians, the American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists, the American Osteopathic Association, and the American Psychiatric Association. "Physicians must be able to practice medicine that is informed by their years of medical education, training, experience, and the available evidence, freely and without threat of punishment."

Read more: *Anti-Trans Violence and Rhetoric Reached Record Highs Across America in 2021*

This focus on gender-affirming pediatricians has extended beyond legislation. As disinformation and fearmongering about trans youth has surged, TIME has spoken with numerous providers who say they've witnessed a rise in harassment in the past two years—whether via in-person protests, online threats and cyberbullying, menacing mail, attempts to cut their research's funding or even their medical licenses. Other gender-affirming pediatricians with whom TIME spoke refused entirely to go on the record, citing fears about the risk of violence against them and their families.

"This is shocking, shocking, shocking," says Dr. Robert Garofalo, the head of adolescent and young adult medicine at Lurie Children's Hospital of Chicago. "No one is prepared for this, and pediatric institutions aren't prepared for it."



The first known protest of gender-affirming pediatricians was in December 2020, per research by Health Liberation Now (HLN), a trans-run advocacy website that researches political impacts on trans health. But by February of 2021, anti-trans groups had announced plans to protest in Los Angeles; Chicago; Philadelphia; Dallas; Hartford, Conn.; and Ontario, Canada. Through the summer and fall of 2021, protests became a more regular occurrence. Some anti-trans groups have begun using an online interactive map that tracks the location of clinics providing gender-affirming care, per HLN's research. Other forms of harassment stay online, but pediatricians say they are similarly frightening—and have been going on since even before the first documented in-person protest.

When Susan, a pediatric endocrinologist, got the call from her hospital's administrative assistant in the fall of 2020, it felt like she'd been punched. (TIME is withholding Susan's identity and that of one other provider out of concerns for their safety.) A patient's family had contacted the hospital, the assistant said, flagging that they'd seen posts online from an account that was purporting to be Susan, but didn't sound like her. Susan rushed to her computer, and sure enough, there was her picture and her name on a Facebook profile, apparently posting about how she regretted her treatment of transgender kids—a feeling that couldn't be

further from the truth. She found a similar fake account on YouTube pretending to be her, expressing “remorse” for her actions.

At least three other gender-affirming pediatricians were impersonated in this incident, Susan tells TIME. Their posts were made to look as if they were in conversation with each other, agreeing about the “harm” they’d done to kids.

“I don’t think I ever went into medicine thinking something like this could happen,” Susan says. “We’re always just trying to care for kids.”

Things have gotten worse. In the spring of 2021, her clinic received threats about protests. In the fall of 2021, the protests actually happened. “It really made us evaluate our safety systems for our patients, families, and staff,” she says. Susan says that she’s repeatedly been threatened with being reported to her state’s medical licensing board—though her care is not in violation of any policies—and adds that she knows gender-affirming mental-health clinicians who have faced similar harassment.

Leigh, a pediatric endocrinologist in the southeast, says people have tweeted at her asking her how she sleeps at night, arguing she is violating God’s plan.

“I am here to take care of my patients and make sure that they live longer, better, healthier lives,” she says. “And to have someone suggest something otherwise is just devastating to me.” Late at night, she’s sometimes filled with a sense of dread over where this rise in harassment could be leading. “We’ve had active shooters in the hospital where I practice for years,” she says. What if one day one of those shooters came looking for her clinic, or even her private home? “That is one of my biggest fears.”

Read more: *America's Foster Care System Is a Dangerous Place for Trans Teens. Now They're Fighting for Change*

Garofalo, of Lurie Children's Hospital, says that at least three of his colleagues in more conservative states reached out in 2021 asking for advice on how to deal with the harassment they were facing. They've told him "horror stories," he says, including instances of receiving death threats.

Dr. Brandon Hill, the former President and CEO of Planned Parenthood Great Plains, which operates in Kansas, Missouri, Oklahoma, and Arkansas, says he's been contacted by children's hospital administrators in major cities across the country asking what trainings he gives abortion providers to prepare them for intense backlash and harassment. "This stuff isn't new. The tactics that these anti-trans-care folks are using have been used to [target abortion providers]," Hill explains. "[But] I don't think we ever thought of this being something where protesters would be outside of adolescent health centers. Ever."

In response, many gender-affirming pediatricians have banded together to be each other's support systems. "There are definitely colleagues who have to worry more about safety than others," says Garofalo. "We check in on each other." They hold wellness events and share experiences.

"We're trying to advocate and be united together," Susan adds. "But I can see the potential for burnout."

The stakes couldn't be higher. A peer-reviewed study published in the *Journal of Adolescent Health* on Dec. 14 found that the use of gender-affirming hormone therapy (GAHT) is significantly related to lower rates of depression, suicidal ideation, and suicide attempts among transgender and nonbinary youth. The study, led by researchers at the LGBTQ suicide prevention nonprofit The Trevor Project, also found that among young trans and nonbinary people under 18, receiving GAHT was associated with nearly 40% lower odds of having had a suicide attempt in the past year. Notably, half of the transgender and nonbinary youth surveyed said they were not receiving GAHT but wanted to.

Several providers said they worry intimidation tactics could ultimately limit the health care options available to transgender and gender expansive youth, who already often face barriers to receiving care, including stigmatization, a lack of familial support, high costs, and onerous travel to reach clinics.

"We don't need another [hurdle]," says Sequeira. "We don't need kids to have to walk through a gauntlet of protesters to get care."

Dr. Janet Cathey, a gender-affirming provider who treats adults and adolescents at the Planned Parenthood in Little Rock, Ark., also worries that primary care doctors considering offering gender-

affirming care might choose otherwise because they don't want to risk wading into controversial territory. In states such as Arkansas, where gender-affirming care for youth was temporarily banned in 2021, providers may feel nervous about treating trans youth because they worry it could threaten their medical license, she says.

In a research study Sequeira has been conducting over the past year, several pediatricians expressed apprehension about starting to offer gender-affirming care, she says, in part because they feared for their safety. "Which is a shame, because we so desperately need more providers in this area," Sequeira says. A lack of available doctors doesn't mean young people will stop needing affirmative care, adds Susan. They might just seek that care in underground ways without the supervision of a doctor, which could be dangerous.

Such an exodus has not occurred in the field of abortion providers, despite decades of dangerous attacks that include bombing, arson, and death threats, explains David S. Cohen, a professor of law at Drexel University and the author of *Living in the Crosshairs: The Untold Stories of Anti-Abortion Terrorism*. However, Cohen adds, many abortion clinics have been forced to close because of financial and regulatory restraints. If the trend of anti-trans legislation continues, the same could happen to gender-affirming care providers, whether or not doctors want to leave the specialty.

"The impact of this harassment is broad. It affects clinical care. It affects research. It even affects philanthropic support, which for a lot of programs has been critical," says Garofalo, who adds that there has already been "tremendous amount of efforts to defund" his research on gender-affirming care with the National Institute of Health.

Read more: *Andraya Yearwood, a Star of Hulu's New Changing the Game Documentary, Talks Life as a Trans Athlete*

In November, the Children's Medical Center Dallas and UT Southwestern Medical Center in Texas dissolved their six-year-old program that offered gender-affirming care to young people. (In a statement to the online news magazine LGBTQNation, the two medical centers said the decision to dissolve the program was the best option to maintain privacy for patients.) The decision came after organized protests that targeted hospital board members and argued that the care equated to child abuse, per the *Texas Tribune*. The program was the only one of its kind in the state.

"That's the part that really breaks my heart about all this," says Sequeira. "There's a lot that's really challenging about being an adolescent, and especially an adolescent who is finding ways to affirm their gender."

"It just makes me so fearful to see the increasing number of protests and discrimination happening to us as providers," she continues, "Knowing that, I can only imagine what's happening in communities, for many, many kids."

—*With reporting by Julia Zorthian*

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The Fight to Save Lives in Ukraine's Largest Children's Hospital

Kyporenko is a journalist and film programmer manager at the Ukrainian Institute in Kyiv, Ukraine.

Sixteen children have died in Ukraine since the start of the Russian invasion on Feb. 24, and 45 have been injured, according to official figures shared with TIME. Many of the wounded are being brought to Okhmatdyt Children's Hospital in the capital Kyiv.

Ukraine's largest pediatric facility has already evacuated patients with non-life-threatening conditions, but there are several children who cannot be removed from life support. Their numbers are growing as fighting around the Ukrainian capital intensifies.

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There has been shelling near the hospital at night, according to surgeon Vitaly Demidov. Corpses and abandoned cars surround the hospital buildings.

“The saddest thing is that when the siren sounds, we have to go down with the children and parents to the basement,” Demidov tells TIME. “We run five or six times a day in the basement and back.”

He said that children on oxygen support needed to keep breathing while being moved, and this meant staff had to run alongside the gurneys operating manual ventilators.

An image of Demidov, with a rifle slung around his torso as he cradles a baby on life support, has gone viral since he posted it to Instagram on Feb. 26. Underneath, he wrote: “’It was very hot tonight. There are very [sick] children in the hospital, oxygen dependent.”

Volunteers have been bringing food, supplies and medicine. “So far, everyone is provided for,” Demidov posted, “but I don’t know for how long.”

Among the wounded is a boy whose 10-year-old sister and parents were reportedly killed by Russian saboteurs.

Another patient is a boy who suffered shrapnel wounds to his neck during the shelling of Kyiv. “Due to the severity of the injury, in

order for us to stop the bleeding the boy had to undergo surgery right in the admission department of the trauma center of the hospital," says pediatric surgeon Oleg Godik. The boy is currently in critical condition and on a ventilator.

Photos shared with TIME by Demidov and other hospital staff show several other children with appalling wounds. In one, a young boy's right cheek has been ripped open. In another, a teenage girl lies on a gurney with leg injuries, her pants shredded and bloodied. One appears to show a young, lifeless body lying under a makeshift covering of cardboard. Several children, including babies, are seen lying in the hospital's basement.

While attempting to save children injured in war, staff are also treating those with preexisting conditions. Amid the shelling, complex surgery was performed on a 15-year-old girl, who arrived four months ago from the Volyn region in Ukraine's northwest, with a diagnosis of lymphoblastic leukemia.

Vadym Tkachuk, the head of the intensive care unit of the Center for Pediatric Cardiology and Cardiac Surgery, says that for now, the intensive care unit has been moved to the basement. Among them are newborn preoperative patients and children after cardiac surgery, many of whom are in serious condition. Some are on ventilators or undergoing dialysis. "There are also patients who are with their parents in the basement," he says. "Currently, we only perform emergency surgeries on patients who [would] die without cardiac surgery. We have to postpone planned operations until the end of this war. The medical staff of the clinic has been working invariably since the beginning of the fighting, as not everyone is able to get to the hospital." As he was writing to TIME, he received information that a child with a congenital heart disease had died because they could not reach the hospital.

Read More: *Even If Russia Wins, It Won't Do So Easily*

Amid all of this, staff attempt to boost the morale of their young patients. Songs are sung and games played during air raids. Two birthdays have even been celebrated in the basement. But the challenges are overwhelming. Natalia Karpenko, head of the intensive care unit, struggles to contain her emotions. “The children are suffering,” she says.

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Despite Decades of Tension, Romanians Are Embracing Ukrainian Refugees

Charlie Campbell is a correspondent at TIME, based in the Singapore bureau. He covers business, tech, and geopolitics across Asia. He was previously China Bureau Chief.

The moment he heard that Russian tanks had entered Ukraine, Daniel Condurache jumped in his car and drove an hour to the Romanian border crossing at Siret. He wanted to offer refugees whatever help he could. “When I first got here it was the middle of the night and there were just three of us and some Orthodox priests helping to translate Ukrainian,” says Condurache, a real estate agent from Botoșani, Romania. “Putin is a criminal and these people don’t deserve this.”

Condurache may have been one of the first to arrive at Siret, but hundreds of his countrymen were close behind. Today, ordinary Romanians flank both sides of the dusty road leaving the border crossing, offering food, water and essentials like soap and diapers to Ukrainian refugees. Lawyers offer free advice on asylum procedures; others, like Condurache, offer transportation and

shelter. “Now everybody’s uniting,” he says. “Romanian people are trying to help all over the country.”

Read More: *Eastern Europe Opens Its Doors and Hearts to People Fleeing Ukraine*

It’s an outpouring of compassion that’s all the more extraordinary given historically testy relations between these neighbors. Following World War II, the USSR annexed the area of Bessarabia from Romania and, somewhat controversially in these parts, it remains part of Ukraine today. That ethnic Romanians in Ukraine aren’t schooled in their native language is a source of constant concern. There’s also a dispute about ecological damage from Ukraine’s Bystroye Canal, which affects both sides of the border, as well as contested Snake Island in the resource-rich Black Sea, where the territorial limits of the surrounding continental shelf were only delineated by the International Court of Justice in 2009. (Snake Island was just the scene of a dramatic, foul-mouthed stand-off between Ukrainian and Russia troops.)

At the moment, though, all this has been forgotten in the face of Russia’s belligerence. “I never even thought of crossing the border to Ukraine or Moldova before, because in my head these places are Russian,” says Condurache. “But now I see these people arriving: this is not Russia.”

Putin's tactics of divide and rule are well-documented. Torrents of Kremlin-backed fake news helped foment Britain's withdrawal from the E.U. and get a polarizing reality television star elected president of the U.S. In two draft treaties that the Russian government published in December, Putin outlined how he sought to restore Moscow's control over Ukraine and former Soviet territories; destroy the North American Treaty Organization (NATO) as an effective alliance; and reduce former Warsaw Pact or USSR countries that are now E.U. members to vassal status, whose security arrangements are the sole purview of the Kremlin.

In Romania, the outrageousness of these demands combined with Putin's savagery in Ukraine has served to galvanize solidarity. "There has been a huge mobilization in support of Ukrainian refugees and Ukraine in general," says Oana Popescu-Zamfir, director of the Bucharest-based Global Focus think tank.

Read More: *Exodus Grows as Nearly 370,000 People Flee Russia's Ukraine Invasion. Millions May Follow*

This is reflected across Europe as tens of thousands have gathered to protest Russia's actions and pressure their own governments into sterner action. On Sunday, the E.U. took the remarkable decision to ban Russian aircraft from its airspace. Russian banks have been cut

out of the SWIFT monetary transfer system, while Germany has boosted its NATO contribution to 2% of GDP. The pressure of sanctions has seen the value of the ruble plummet by 40% against the dollar, prompting the Kremlin to spike interest rates from 9.5 to 20%. And at border crossings around Ukraine's periphery, ordinary Slovakians, Hungarians, Moldavians and Poles have come out to welcome the influx.

It's particularly significant since Ukraine's western neighbors, such as Hungary and Slovakia, have consistently ranked among the least accepting in the world for migrants, and of them only Moldova voted for the U.N. migration pact in 2018. That said, while opening his borders to refugees, Hungarian's strongman President Viktor Orbán has said he would not allow lethal weapons to be transferred to Ukrainian resistance through his territory.

Warnings of Russian Aggression Unheeded

Yet in Eastern Europe, there's also a sense of irritation that Western European nations, especially Germany, France and Italy, which rely on Russian energy, dragged their heels on Putin's aggression despite so many warning signs—not least his 2008 incursion into Georgia and the 2014 annexation of Crimea.

"There's a widespread perception—not just in Romania but across Central Eastern Europe—that Western Europe did not take our warnings about Russian aggression seriously enough," says Popescu-Zamfir. Too late, perhaps, but the threat of Putin's Russia is no longer a matter of debate. For the first time ever Friday, NATO activated its Response Force consisting of land, air, sea and special operations, which can deploy quickly in support of the alliance. "I have never heard so many people say that it's such a blessing for Romania to be a NATO member," adds Popescu-Zamfir.

Read More: *'We Will Defend Ourselves.' Photographs of Ukraine Under Attack*

The depth of support for the Ukrainian resistance is why many observers believe Putin agreed to have talks with a Ukrainian delegation at the border with Belarus, "without preconditions." Yet many of the over 500,000 people who had fled Ukraine by Monday, according to the U.N., doubt whether a negotiated settlement is feasible and are planning to help their homeland with funds. Among them is Maria Menieva, 24, a choral conductor from the western Ukrainian city of Lyiv, who TIME met Sunday crossing into Siret with her violinist boyfriend and cocker spaniel, Gary. "We're heading to Denmark to earn money to give to the Ukrainian army," she says. "I have two brothers fighting and I'm so scared for them."

Many from across Europe are prepared to help with more than just cash. On Sunday, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy announced the Ukrainian armed forces were setting up a foreign legion unit for international volunteers. In response, U.K. Foreign Secretary Liz Truss has said she supports Britons wanting to join up, telling the BBC that it was a battle "for democracy" and "not just for Ukraine but for the whole of Europe." Sure enough, at the Siret border crossing, TIME observed two thick-set men with

British accents and paramilitary dress conspiratorially discussing how best to cross over into Ukraine. (TIME was unable to confirm if their plan was indeed to join the fight against Russia.)

Voicu Muresanu, 26, a videographer from Romanian university city of Cluj, came to Siret to document the refugee exodus but has been so appalled by the suffering that he's seriously thinking about picking up a gun. "Lots of my friends are researching how to join the Ukrainian army," he says. "I don't want to go there, I'm scared sh-tless, but I feel that if 5 million people did then this war would be over in two days."

Others believe that it's down to the West to teach Putin a lesson. "Europe and America should do more," says Condurache. "[President Joe] Biden is a good guy but I think he should send soldiers. Putin is crazy, he is like Hitler, and will want more countries," Condurache adds, gesturing to the lines of bedraggled women and children trundling past. "No normal person could bomb these guys like that."

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The Window to Adapt to Climate Change Is ‘Rapidly Closing,’ Warns the IPCC

Kyla Mandel is a senior editor at TIME. She oversees climate, science, and space coverage.

Justin Worland is a senior correspondent at TIME in the Washington, D.C. bureau. He received Covering Climate Now's inaugural Climate Journalist of the Year award in 2022, among other awards.

After decades of failure to stop emissions rising, a landmark new report released Monday from the United Nations’ climate-science body warns that the impacts of climate change are here and now humans need to accelerate efforts to adapt.

“It is unequivocal that climate change has already disrupted human and natural systems,” states the report’s summary for policymakers.

The next decade will prove a crucial test of whether the world can move fast enough to implement plans to adapt to this increasingly complex challenge. “Any further delay in concerted anticipatory

global action on adaptation and mitigation will miss a brief and rapidly closing window of opportunity to secure a livable and sustainable future for all," the report says.

The report, produced by the U.N. Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC), comes as part of the agency's most comprehensive assessment on climate change since 2014. It's the second of three planned reports, the first of which was released in August 2021 and made clear the world was on track to surpass 1.5°C of warming, a threshold widely considered likely to trigger catastrophic and irreversible effects.

Typically, policymakers divide climate policy into two categories: adaptation and mitigation. Mitigation incorporates all the actions that can reduce emissions and thus limit future damage, while adaptation covers how we prepare ourselves and adjust to a warmer world. For decades, mitigation has received the lion's share of attention from scientists, activists, and policymakers—and funding—for an obvious reason: more mitigation means less need for adaptation down the road.

The new IPCC report is a signal of how dramatically that thinking has changed. "For too long, there was concern among many in the climate community that highlighting the acute need for investment in adaptation would undermine the importance of reducing emissions," says Nat Keohane, president of the Center for Climate and Energy Solutions. This "report should put that debate to rest for good." The truth is we need both—and urgently.

At the root of that urgency are the clear damages already harming not just human society but also natural ecosystems. Coral reefs and forested areas, including in the Amazon, are among the ecosystems that face the threat of catastrophic climate tipping points—after which the impacts are irreversible—without a clear pathway to restoration. This in turn shapes human civilization both because locals depend on these ecosystems for everything from food to

clean air and because they hold carbon that would otherwise enter the atmosphere and worsen global warming.

Humans are generally better able to adapt than natural ecosystems, the report says, but nonetheless many communities are running up against their limits to sustain human life. Adaptation cannot prevent all losses and damages—there are some negative impacts of climate that the world simply will not be able to prevent. And not every community will be able to adapt or respond the same way. “There are limits to adaptation,” says Adelle Thomas, a researcher at Climate Analytics and one of the new IPCC report’s many contributing authors. “We are already finding that while some people and places are adapting, they are being pushed beyond their abilities to adapt.”

Among the most vulnerable are people living in low-lying coastal regions such as those in Australasia; residents of small islands such as those in Micronesia; and smallholder farmers around the world. Investing in adaptation projects can help not only protect people from climate impacts, but also improve agricultural productivity and provide food security, protect human health and well-being, and safeguard livelihoods. But to do this successfully, more financing is needed to tackle what the report calls a growing “adaptation gap” between those who can afford to invest in sometimes costly adaptation projects and those who may not be able to.

And, if not done properly, “maladaptation” risks locking communities into even greater climate vulnerability, at an even higher cost, further exacerbating existing inequalities. “The science could not be more clear,” says Tina Stege, climate envoy for the Marshall Islands. “Failing to adapt to this crisis will cost lives. Failing to provide fair, accessible climate finance will cost lives. Continued dependence on fossil fuels will cost lives. With the consequences of inaction spelled out so clearly, yet again, a failure to act is inhuman and unconscionable.”

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Biden Will Nominate Ketanji Brown Jackson to The Supreme Court. Here's What Happens Next

Abby Vesoulis is a political reporter in TIME's Washington bureau.

In 1967, Thurgood Marshall became the first Black Supreme Court Justice. In 1981, Sandra Day O'Connor became the first woman Supreme Court Justice. Now, Ketanji Brown Jackson is poised to become the first Black woman to sit on the highest court in the land.

President Joe Biden has selected the D.C. Circuit Judge to replace retiring Justice Stephen Breyer, the White House confirmed Friday morning. Jackson, 51, had been rumored to be the President's top choice since she was confirmed to the the D.C. Circuit last year by a vote of 53-44, with three Republican senators voting in her favor.

Jackson would bring a variety of professional experiences currently lacking from the Supreme Court, having not built a career as a prosecutor or corporate lawyer. She served as a federal public defender from 2005 to 2007, and would be the first Justice since Marshall who represented indigent criminal defendants. From 2010

to 2014, Jackson served as vice chair of the bipartisan U.S. Sentencing Commission, a period during which the commission reassessed the 100-to-1 crack versus powder cocaine sentencing disparity.

In recent weeks, Biden had whittled his list down to just a few names, including South Carolina District Judge J. Michelle Childs and California Supreme Court Justice Leondra Kruger. His team ran detailed background checks on all three finalists.

After Biden officially announces his choice, the process moves over to Congress. Former Democratic Alabama Sen. Doug Jones has been tasked by the White House to be Jackson's "sherpa," meaning he'll work to help her navigate the Hill in what can be a deeply contentious process. Jones will help Jackson arrange meetings with Senators from both sides of the aisle to try and garner their support ahead of the final confirmation vote. Such meetings have been pivotal in past nomination processes, one Democratic Judiciary Committee aide says.

Jackson will appear before the Senate Judiciary Committee, chaired by Democrat Dick Durbin of Illinois, where she'll face days of questioning about her career, past rulings and judicial philosophy. Nearly every member of Durbin's Judiciary Committee nominations team has worked on a Supreme Court nomination in the past. Now that they have the name of the President's pick, they'll begin poring over her case records, publications, public statements and rulings—and will give that information to other committee Democrats so they can begin evaluating her record and writing their questions. Supreme Court nominees must submit a questionnaire on their career history as part of the hearing, which historically has been tailored to each nominee and agreed upon by both Republican and Democrats on the committee, according to a Republican Senate Judiciary Committee aide.

Democratic Judiciary Committee aides tell TIME they've been preparing for this moment for weeks, mindful that the speed at which they can move a nominee through the process hinges on whether she's come before the committee before. Since Jackson went before the Committee just a year earlier—and confirmed with little drama—they expect the process will be swifter than if she was new to the Judiciary Committee.

While a source close to Senate Majority Leader Chuck Schumer told CNN last month that Schumer hopes for a timeline similar to the confirmation of Justice Amy Coney Barrett—who was confirmed in less than five weeks in the fall of 2020—Democratic Judiciary Committee aides say that "the chair sets the timeline." Aides say Durbin will ensure Senators on the committee will have the opportunity to speak with the nominee, review her record and "question her thoroughly about that record." Taylor Foy, the communications director for the committee's ranking member Republican Sen. Chuck Grassley of Iowa, says he'd expect a timeline closer to 45 days.

Jackson does not need the support of any Republicans on the committee to advance to the Senate floor for a vote to confirm her to the Supreme Court. Sen. Lindsey Graham of South Carolina, a Republican on the committee, voted to confirm Jackson to the D.C. Circuit just last year, although he'd publicly backed South Carolina District Judge Childs for the Supreme Court spot since Breyer announced his retirement. Graham told reporters on Feb. 2 that Childs is "somebody I could see myself supporting." He warned that if Biden's pick isn't Childs, it could be "much more problematic."

Once her nomination is processed by the committee, Jackson needs just 51 Senate votes to be confirmed. (Supreme Court nominees used to require the support of 60 Senators, but in 2017 the Republican-controlled Senate created a filibuster carve out for Supreme Court nominations to confirm Justice Neil Gorsuch.)

Democrats want to move quickly to get Jackson to the final vote. If a Democratic Senator retires, falls ill or passes away, they could lose their fragile 50-50 majority in the Senate—the stakes of which were highlighted earlier this month after New Mexico Democrat Sen. Ben Ray Luján suffered a stroke and underwent decompressive surgery to ease swelling in his brain. (In mid-February, Luján reported he would be back on the floor of the Senate “in just a few short weeks to vote on important legislation and to consider a Supreme Court nominee.” On Feb. 18, he tweeted that he was in inpatient care.)

While Democrats do not need Republican support to confirm Biden’s nominee, Senate Democratic aides say that Durbin has preemptively reached out to Republican colleagues to discuss the confirmation process, including Sens. Grassley, Graham and Susan Collins of Maine. They say Durbin is also leaning on his close relationship with Thom Tillis of North Carolina, and has close relationships with Lisa Murkowski of Alaska, Todd Young of Indiana, and Jerry Moran of Kansas that may help ensure the process runs smoothly.

While Jackson could win an historic confirmation in the coming weeks, she won’t change the ideological balance of the court. There are six conservative Justices on the Supreme Court and three liberal Justices, and her confirmation wouldn’t change that makeup.

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To Solve Long-Term Inflation, America Needs More Babies and Immigrants

Alana Semuels is an economic correspondent at TIME. She covers work, consumer spending, retail, gender, and technology. She is a four-time nominee for the Gerald Loeb Award for Distinguished Business and Financial Journalism, and has won awards from the Society of Business Editors and Writers and the Los Angeles Press Club.

The cost of goods is rising and rising—6.1% last year, according to government numbers released on Friday, Feb 25—and lots of ink has been spilled explaining why. Consumers have more money in their pockets thanks to wage gains and increased savings during lockdowns, so demand for goods is up, but production slowed during the pandemic. Supply chain snafus have made it more expensive to get things from one place to another, so companies are raising prices. Energy prices have been rising, and the war in Ukraine will only drive them higher.

But the simplest explanation may be this: because of long-term demographic shifts, the U.S., like many other countries, simply

doesn’t have enough workers to make and move all the things that people want to buy anymore. Too many older people have dropped out of the workforce, never to return, and too few young people and immigrants are coming to replace them. There are 11 million job openings in the U.S. economy right now, yet there are only 6.5 million people who are unemployed.

“All of our gaps in the supply chain are because people aren’t there to make the goods. This is the problem. It’s a lack of labor,“ says Ron Hetrick, senior economist at Emsi Burning Glass, a global labor market data and analytics company that put out a report on Feb. 22, The Demographic Drought: Bridging the Gap in Our Labor Force. More than half of the 5 million people who dropped out of the labor force since early 2020 are 55 or older, Hetrick calculates. (The Census Bureau suggests that early retirements account for 3.4 million people.)

The demographic shift is driving prices up in industries including transportation, manufacturing, and construction, to name a few. Consumer packaged goods company Post Holdings, Inc., which owns brands like Raisin Bran, said in an earnings call on Feb. 4 that internal and external labor shortages had driven up the cost of its products last quarter. United Airlines said in January that because of a pilot shortage, it was cutting services to around 20 U.S. communities—like many airlines, United saw retirements accelerate during the pandemic. And Albertsons, the grocery chain, said in a January earnings call that because of labor shortages, it was paying workers more overtime, which led to some price increases.

The worrying part of demographic-driven inflation is that it’s not going away anytime soon. Last year, the U.S. population grew at 0.1%, its slowest rate since the nation’s founding, according to Census Data. And still the population continues to age as the fertility rate declines. By 2034, older adults will outnumber children for the first time in U.S. history. The share of the

population that is under 20 years old has been steadily declining, from 27% in 2007 to 25% in 2020.

Economists also thought that Baby Boomers— born between 1946 and 1964—would stay in the labor market for longer. Boomers drove high labor participation rates in the 1970s and 1980s because so many women joined the workforce. And Boomers were workaholics, Hetrick says, so economists assumed they'd work until they dropped.

But instead, when the pandemic hit, Boomers took stock of their finances and decided to retire. Over the last few years their homes had only gotten more valuable and their stock market portfolios had grown, so they decided to take a step back and not risk contracting COVID-19. The average expected likelihood of working beyond age 62 declined to a new low of 49.3% in November, according to a survey from the Federal Reserve Bank of New York.

This might not have been a problem if workers were coming from other parts of the population to fill the gap. Historically, immigration has helped shore up the labor force when demographic trends lead to worker shortages. But immigration, too, has been falling since 2016. Net international migration in 2021 was just 247,000, the lowest number in at least a decade and about one-quarter of what it was in 2016.

"Falling immigration had already started happening, but it was worsened by COVID," says Hetrick. "Baby boomers were already starting to retire—but COVID could not have come at a worse time."

It may be difficult to reverse these numbers, especially because trends of declining birth rates and aging populations aren't unique to the U.S. Other countries that have typically provided the U.S. with workers, such as Mexico, also have historically low

unemployment rates. The economic conditions in other countries that have long driven immigrants to the U.S. may not be as dire as they used to be, as strict immigration policies enacted during the Trump administration have made it harder for people to migrate to the U.S.

Meanwhile, U.S. consumers are still spending as if nothing has changed, and so demand for goods and services is high. American consumers spent $337.2 billion in January, according to the latest data, a 2.1% increase from December.

Consumers in states like Maine, New Hampshire, and Pennsylvania are already seeing the labor issues that come with an aging population. These are states that are already “super-aged,” meaning that 20% of the population is 65 or older, a designation the entire U.S. will reach in 2028. They’re already facing big labor shortages because of retirements and a lack of workers.

“We’ve been trying to recruit for six months, but virtually no one who is applying is qualified,” says Julia Griffin, the town manager of Hanover, N.H., who is trying to hire a senior planner, two building inspectors, staff for after-school programs, and a zoning officer, among other positions. “We have an unusually high number of vacancies,” she says.

Griffin says she knows she’s going to have to increase wages and benefits to attract more applicants, but taypayers will push back on higher costs. Worried that the town won’t have anyone to plow the roads down the line, she started researching autonomous snow plows. (They don’t yet exist.) Some residents are themselves quitting jobs because they can’t find programs—like after-school programs—that the town would have put on in the past, creating a vicious cycle of a shrinking workforce.

This is just the beginning of a demographic shift that’s going to play out in the economy for the next few decades. It has

implications for many sectors, including health care, elder care, and housing. Right now, though, consumers may see the most obvious effects of this demographic shift in their pocketbook.

“Every economist I’ve heard who says, ‘inflation is going to last this long or that long,’ I say, ‘Do you have a crystal ball that tells you exactly when these people are going to come back to the labor force?’” Hetrick says. “If we do not get the Boomers back, and immigration does not improve, I’m just telling you the math—I’m not sure how we get back to growth.”

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Why Trump's TRUTH Social Platform Will Struggle to Compete With Mainstream Social Media

Megan McCluskey is a staff writer at TIME. She covers culture, focusing on horror, fantasy, and science fiction.

With the launch of former President Donald Trump's new social media platform, TRUTH Social, originally planned for Feb. 21 but now delayed until late March, Trump's ability to galvanize conservative social media users in support of the venture could soon be tested. Its initial press has claimed it will "stand up to the tyranny of Big Tech." But experts say the inherent nature of the site—i.e., catering to a specific idealogical viewpoint—will likely prevent it from reaching the same heights as mainstream platforms like Facebook, Twitter, or Discord.

Social media platforms become more useful to the public as the number of people using them increases, says Joshua Tucker, co-director of NYU's Center for Social Media and Politics.

"The more people who join, the more value [these sites] provide. That's a fundamental premise of social media," he says. "So when you start out by lopping off [a large percentage] of the population, that gets more challenging because it's harder to scale. And that's especially the case when there are alternatives out there that have don't have the same limitations as you."

From Twitter knockoffs Parler, Gab and GETTR to YouTube competitor Rumble, TRUTH Social has been preceded by a number of other free-speech-centric platforms that have become right-wing havens. However, none have risen to large scale success.

Read More: *What's Allowed on Trump's New 'TRUTH' Social Media Platform—And What Isn't*

While there is a market for alternative social platforms that target specific communities, Kristina Lerman, a research professor of computer science and principal scientist at the University of Southern California's Information Sciences Institute, says that such sites aren't going to replace platforms that attract a more diverse set of the population.

"There's a whole social network for beer enthusiasts where they can come together and post reviews of beers," she says. "It's great that such a community exists where like-minded people can meet each other. But that doesn't mean that kind of niche community will be attractive to the mainstream."

Although TRUTH Social's expected release date is still listed as Feb. 21 on the Apple App Store, the stock price of Digital World Acquisition Corp.—the blank-check company that's partnered with Trump Media & Technology Group (TMTG) to fund TRUTH Social—plunged earlier this month as news spread of a delay in the platform's launch. Former congressman Devin Nunes, the recently appointed CEO of TMTG, has said the app will now be released by March 31.

Neither Nunes nor TRUTH Social immediately responded to TIME's request for comment.

Still, Tucker says that TRUTH Social's launch could be a "watershed moment" for the future of alternative social media sites popular with conservatives.

"A couple of things could happen [with the TRUTH Social launch]," he says. "By his sheer force of personality, Trump could suck the air out of Parler, Gab, GETTR, all these sites and pull everybody over. And [that would mean the site] could break

through the critical threshold and actually get big enough to support real ad revenue…If Trump's able to do that, it probably means the rest of those platforms fade away and we're in a new world where we have the mainstream platforms and one really big right-wing platform."

However, if he can't do that, "then this conversation about whether someone can establish a big right-wing platform likely goes away."

When it comes to their ability to compete with the big dogs, politically-oriented platforms like TRUTH Social tend to lack some of the more popular social aspects—from photos of friends and family to localized groups and events—of mainstream sites, says Tucker.

"When we think about what people are getting out of social media networks, there's obviously a political component to it, but there can be a huge asymmetry between the impact of social media networks on politics and the importance people place on the political aspects of social media networks compared to everything else they're getting out of them," he says. "So if you have a politically organized platform, it's not giving users exposure to people [in a lot of different social capacities] like social media normally does."

Read More: *What to Know About Digital World, the Company Funding Trump's New Social Media Platform 'TRUTH Social'*

This reasoning also helps explain why right-wing personalities with major followings on Twitter and other mainstream platforms often experience an initial surge in audience growth followed by a prolonged period of stagnation, or even decline, when making the switch to these alternative sites. "There's excitement originally, but then people get on [the site] and it has less [social] value," Tucker says. "So they go there to get their fix of right-wing politics and then they pull out of it."

An analysis conducted by the Washington *Post* of audience data for 47 prominent right-wing influencers who made the jump to alternative social networks Gab and GETTR, the video platform Rumble, and the chat service Telegram following Trump's ban from Twitter, Facebook and YouTube last year found that the number of people following these personalities has barely grown since briefly spiking in January 2021.

That means right-wing influencers who haven't been kicked off mainstream platforms could face a difficult decision when deciding whether to make the leap to leave them behind.

"If you go to one of these right-wing platforms and leave Facebook and Twitter, you're leaving a lot of potential people behind who you could be spreading your message to," Tucker says. "If you don't leave the mainstream platforms behind, the people who follow you to one of these new places might migrate back because they know they can still get their fix of you on Twitter and also find out what the weather is in their area or what gasoline prices are like or whatever they're using Twitter for."

While the success of TRUTH Social will depend on whether the site can find ways to keep users engaged after that original sign-up period, Lerman maintains that ideologically different platforms carving out a place in the Big Tech space could be beneficial for everyone.

"It could decrease the temperature on Twitter by siphoning off the more extreme people and giving them a platform to communicate outside of that space," she says. "As a result, maybe Twitter would become less polarized and the discussions would be more even-tempered."

But without any new technological innovation to offer, Tucker is skeptical that TRUTH Social can break out and become the "major rival to Big Tech" that it's advertised itself as.

“The innovations we get in social media are not by carving up the population into smaller groups, but by introducing new features that people like,” he says. “I haven’t seen a ton of success for this one-trick pony of ‘we’re going to be a free speech site and we’re not going to censor you.’”

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What the World Can Learn from China's COVID-19 Rules at the Winter Olympics

Chad de Guzman is a reporter for TIME based in Singapore. He covers the Asia-Pacific region and global overnight news.

China promised a "simple, safe, and splendid" Beijing Olympics. While the elaborate, anti-COVID measures at the 2022 Winter Games were far from simple, organizers managed to put on a show, even amid the constrained circumstances of a global health crisis. There's also no doubt that the event was safe.

COVID-19 has been surging around the world, fueled by the more contagious Omicron variant. On Dec. 27, just over a month before the Winter Games began, global daily COVID-19 cases hit a record 1.44 million.

Despite these daunting circumstances, Olympics organizers had recorded only 437 infections at the Games by the time the flame was extinguished at Beijing National Stadium on Feb. 20. Though more than 180 athletes and team officials tested positive after

arriving in China, there were no major disruptions to events caused by outbreaks.

For China, containing the coronavirus on an epic scale is not new. The country unhesitatingly puts entire cities on weeks-long lockdown, and conducts massive testing, tracing, and vaccination operations, under its “dynamic zero COVID” policy. It can’t afford to do otherwise: some estimates show that China would have suffered as many as 200 million infections and 3 million deaths by now, if it had attempted to “live with the virus” as most countries do. Instead, less than 131,000 cases and 4,924 deaths have been recorded in China since the start of the pandemic.

In this context, it was vital that the staging of the Olympics—with thousands of participants arriving from 91 countries—not lead to a wider community outbreak. To protect its citizens, China ran the Beijing Olympics on a strict “closed loop” system: participants and venues were confined to epidemiological bubbles, strictly segregated from the city at large.

Read more: *What to Know About the 2022 Winter Olympics Closing Ceremony*

“They basically thought of the bubble as a similar kind of setting [to the rest of the country],” says Karen Grépin, an associate professor at the School of Public Health at the University of Hong Kong.

It worked. Participants testing positive recovered in the loop, with many continuing to compete. Speaking at a press conference on Feb. 18, International Olympic Committee (IOC) president Thomas Bach said the infection rate at the event stayed at 0.01%. He called the closed loop “one of the safest” places on Earth.

Although some athletes pushed back against the rigors of Beijing’s approach, the Winter Games demonstrated China’s capability to

keep Omicron at bay—something no other country has done effectively. They reveal just how much cooperation, organization, and expenditure are required to stage a large scale international event safely. Grépin calls the Olympics “an enormous planning effort,” based on “two years of really good data and evidence in terms of how COVID-19 spreads.”

How the Beijing Olympics kept Omicron at bay

Beijing is the second city to stage the Games during the COVID-19 pandemic, and it tried to learn as much as it could from Tokyo’s infection control playbook for the Summer Olympics last year. A surge in cases occurred after the Tokyo Games ended in August. Both the IOC and Japan denied that the Games caused the spike, but this was an area that Beijing especially wanted to address.

Around 19,000 local volunteers agreed to spend up to two months away from their families to help out at the Games. It meant that they would not spend Lunar New Year—China’s most important holiday—with their loved ones. To prevent any chance of a post-Olympics outbreak, they also consented to undergo a 21-day quarantine after the Olympics before being allowed home. One volunteer said “professional psychological training” was given to help them adjust “our mental state.”

From the time Beijing's closed loop system took effect on Jan. 23, organizers administered more than 1.8 million COVID-19 tests—at least one per day for everyone involved. Masks and contract-tracing apps were naturally mandatory. On-site spectators were kept at a minimum. As a televised and online spectacle, the 2022 Olympics were the most watched Winter Games ever. But over its 19 days, only 150,000 people saw in person the sporting events in Beijing and neighboring Zhangjiakou.

Athletes, upon arriving in China, had to mostly stay in their rooms when not training or competing. Not all were up to the challenge. U.S. snowboarder Jamie Anderson—who won gold in 2014 and 2018 but failed to medal in Beijing—told *USA Today* that most of the U.S. snowboard team was "tired of the pressure," and "a little bit tapped out." Some athletes testing positive complained about the lack of training equipment and the quality of the meals in quarantine, although gripes do seem to have been eventually addressed. Belgian competitor Kim Meylemans briefly made headlines with a tearful Instagram video after she tested positive for COVID-19 on arrival in Beijing and was sent to an isolation facility, even though subsequent tests were negative. She was brought back to the Olympic Village a few hours later.

Read more: *What Happens if an Athlete Gets COVID-19 at 2022 Olympics?*

"Such kind of isolation is a challenge for everybody, but for the athletes, it's the heaviest to bear," Bach told media. But he said that while the isolation facilities in Beijing "did not work perfectly," Olympic officials made efforts to fix issues that came up.

Many athletes actually welcomed the infection control protocols. American freestyle skier Aaron Blunck said that China did a "stellar job" with the COVID-19 measures. Britt Cox, a four-time Olympian, told Australian state-funded broadcaster ABC that

regular testing inside the bubble gave her "a lot of peace of mind" and allowed her to focus on competing.

Canadian figure skater Keegan Messing missed the team skating sporting event after testing positive for COVID-19 before his flight to Beijing, but recovered just in time to travel to the Olympics and skate in the men's single's category. While he "had not seen anything of Beijing, other than a bus, my room or the rink," he lauded what he thought was a "great" atmosphere in the Games. As for the restrictions, Messing told TIME that athletes had already have been dealing with COVID measures for most of the season: "So how strict Beijing is, it's just really another competition for us."

Among athletes testing positive, only a few were unable to actually compete. Vincent Zhou had to withdraw from the men's figure skating competition after testing positive, but that was after he helped the U.S. win silver in team figure skating. (No other team members tested positive.) Neither did a positive test end the dream of making the podium. Three-time U.S. bobsled medalist Elana Meyers Taylor recovered from infection in Beijing—and bagged silver for the inaugural women's monobob event.

Learning from Beijing's 'closed loop' system

Lessons on how to stage a virus-free international event can be learned from the Beijing Olympics, experts say, even in countries that don't follow zero-COVID policies. "You might receive some resistance," says Dr. Huang Yanzhong, senior fellow for global health at the Council of Foreign Relations, "but I still believe that is doable."

Grépin agrees, saying that Beijing has set a new benchmark: "It's sort of a gold standard that isn't necessarily what other places that are not striving for zero COVID will need to put into place."

Read more: *Don't Expect China to Ease Its Zero-COVID Policy Soon*

It may be premature to call the closed-loop system a total success. The system will still be in place until the end of the Paralympics in March, and only when volunteers re-enter the community will its effectiveness be truly known. "When they dismantle the bubble, we're going to have to test and see what will happen," says Grépin.

But putting together tens of thousands of people in a closed loop, with many flying in from countries currently being ravaged by Omicron, and managing to keep a highly contagious disease at bay, is a feat that can't be denied to China.

"This is a great achievement," Bach told reporters. "It may send the message to the world that if everybody is respecting the rules in solidarity, and if everybody's contributing, then you can even have such a great event like Olympic Winter Games under the terms of such a pandemic."

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Sarah Al Amiri: The Woman Who Took the U.A.E. to Mars

Jeffrey Kluger is an editor at large at TIME. He covers space, climate, and science. He is the author of 12 books, including *Apollo 13*, which served as the basis for the 1995 film, and was nominated for an Emmy Award for TIME's series A Year in Space.

Sarah Al Amiri was in COVID-19 quarantine after arriving in Japan in July 2020 when she learned news beyond anything she had ever dreamed of: while scrolling through Twitter to pass the time, she learned that the government of the United Arab Emirates was reshuffling some of its higher ranking offices and officers and that Amiri, now 35, was being appointed chairwoman of the United Arab Emirates Space Agency (UAESA)—the equivalent of NASA Administrator.

Amiri was already a member of the U.A.E. Prime Minister’s office, serving as Minister of State for Science—she was in Japan for the launch of her country’s first Mars mission, aboard a Japanese Mitsubishi rocket. Yet she says the news still stunned her. “I was shocked. I think that is the right word,” she recalls.

Shocked at the honor and the responsibility that came with it, perhaps, but she could not have been entirely surprised. Amiri has been fascinated with space since she was 12 years old, when she first saw a picture of the Andromeda galaxy and learned that it is 2.5 million light years from Earth—an almost unfathomable distance. However, given that space exploration was still in the hands of just a few of the world's largest nations, it seemed unlikely to a young Amiri that a country like the U.A.E. would reach space any time soon. So rather than anything directly space-related, Amiri studied computer programming in college. But by the time she graduated in 2009, the first green shoots of an Emirati space program had begun to sprout. She applied to join UAESA and was hired at 22 as a 22-year-old software engineer, working on an advanced aerial systems program.

The U.A.E. launched its first Earth observation satellite, Dubai SAT, in 2009, followed by Dubai SAT 2 in 2013. Then, in 2014, it set its space ambitions far higher, announcing a goal to send a probe to Martian orbit by 2021—the country's 50th anniversary. That gave UAESA only seven years to plan the kind of mission that usually requires a decade or more of preparation. Amiri was named deputy project manager and science lead on the mission, which had the ambitious goal of mapping Mars's entire atmosphere over a whole Martian year (687 Earth days).

The spacecraft Amiri's team designed and built for the mission was dubbed Hope—a 1,380 kg (3,000 lb.) SUV-sized vehicle that took seven months to reach the Red Planet. Waiting for news of the spacecraft's arrival on February 9, 2021, was, says Amiri, "the toughest point." But this time, instead of being in quarantine, she was standing outside the Burj Khalifa—the tallest building in the world—and celebrating with the crowds who had gathered to mark the moment.

The Hope spacecraft has now been studying the Martian atmosphere for close to a year, sending down regular tranches of

data which UAESA shares freely with the world. Among the craft's most noteworthy discoveries: the detection of what's known as a "discrete aurora" on the nighttime side of the planet—a phenomenon caused by solar energy interacting with crustal formations that still bear traces of the planet's long-gone magnetic field. Other spacecraft have seen the discrete aurorae, but none have seen it as sharply or mapped it as precisely as Hope. The spacecraft also detected dramatic variations in atomic oxygen and carbon monoxide in Mars's dayside atmosphere; previous studies led scientists to expect more uniform distributions of the two gasses.

The mission's successes have not only made contributions to science, but helped put the Emirates' space program in the cosmic big leagues. "The U.A.E. has been very ambitious in developing an outstanding space program," says Pascale Ehrenfreund, research professor of space policy and international affairs at George Washington University's Space Policy Institute. The country's achievements—which, aside from the Hope mission and the Earth observation satellites, have included sending an astronaut to the International Space Station—"are symbolic of a new era in the region," Ehrenfreund says.

The Hope mission was not just ambitious in terms of its scope, but also in terms of gender representation. Amiri's science team included 80% women, an unusual number in the field of space exploration. She has always been determined that gender would not in any way hold her back in her chosen field. "I grew up to be—and continue to be—deaf to the challenges pertaining to gender," she says.

However, Amiri is aware of the challenges for women advancing in the field of science. In her work as Minister of State for Advanced Technology, she has helped put together a team that has focused exclusively on women in sciences—addressing what she describes as "a leaky pipeline" that too often sees women drop out of STEM programs before beginning their careers. "It's something that exists

and something that you need to acknowledge exists, and by acknowledging it, you're able to treat it," Amiri says.

Ehrenfreund believes that Amiri can help plug that leak, setting a standard for other women to follow. "Her successful career from computer science and space research responsibilities to becoming Minister of State for Advanced Technology in the government of the United Arab Emirates is certainly exemplary," she says.

As for the U.A.E.'s ambitions in space, Amiri is not standing still. The country's next major mission, which will be launched in 2028, will involve a flyby of Venus as well as a tour of seven different asteroids, culminating with a landing on the last of them, making the U.A.E. just the fourth country in the world to pull off such an acrobatic maneuver. The country may be taking its first, early steps into space, but led by Amiri, it's taking them confidently.

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Contract Nurse Agencies Are Making Big Money in the Age of COVID-19. Are They ‘Exploiting’ the Pandemic?

Abby Vesoulis is a political reporter in TIME's Washington bureau.

Abigail Abrams is a politics writer for TIME.

In the 40 years that Jennie Kahn has worked as a registered nurse, the last two have been by far the most grueling.

A lot of that is due to COVID-19, which transformed health care facilities, including Thomas Health’s hospital system in Charleston, West Virginia, where Kahn works, into triage centers and forced nurses to take on an extraordinary amount of personal risk and heartache. It’s no mystery why some 18% of health care workers quit their jobs between Feb 2020 and Sept 2021, according to a Morning Consult poll.

But another reason these past two years have been so punishing, Kahn says, is that hospital nursing staffs have been subject to extraordinary churn as thousands of nurses have quit their staff

positions to become contract travel nurses, where the pay is often two to four times higher. This rapid turnover has triggered a costly feedback loop: hospital administrators, facing shortages in staff nurses, spend a mint hiring contract nurses, which makes them less able or willing to increase their staff nurses' pay. So more staff nurses quit to become contract nurses, thus further lowering nurse supply and driving demand for contract nurses. "It is a vicious cycle," says Kahn, the hospital system's chief nursing officer.

Meanwhile, contract nursing agencies have increased their prices. The advertised pay rate for travel nurses has surged 67% from January 2020 to January 2022, according to Prolucent Health, a workforce management tool for healthcare companies, while some staffing agencies such as AMN Healthcare, told TIME that pay rates for travel nurses at facilities they work with rose by 164% from the fourth quarter of 2019 to the fourth quarter of 2021. Some of these agencies' profit margins top 20%.

Some hospital administrators, many of which saw their facilities' profits shrivel during COVID, say they've reached a crisis point and are calling on Congress and the Biden Administration to step in. They argue that contract nursing agencies are exploiting circumstances resulting from COVID-19 to pad their own pockets. The agencies say their prices are merely a reflection of growing demand. Nurses, meanwhile, argue that hospital administrators, who are somehow finding a way to pay premium rates for contract nurses, could have avoided the mass nurse exodus by paying their staff nurses better and improving working conditions from the start, and that a fragmented nursing force with quick turnover is bad for patients' health.

The solution is not straight-forward. Health care facilities, desperate to keep nurses on staff, may have to improve salaries and working conditions, but at many facilities, that's easier said than done. At long-term care centers, bottom lines are dictated by Medicare and Medicaid reimbursement, and at many small and

medium-sized hospitals, the cost of personal protective equipment and patient loads have fluctuated dramatically since March 2020.

“This is not anything that any health system can sustain for a long period of time,” says Kahn. “If the rates do not decrease or if travel nursing is not reduced somewhat, hospital systems are going to have to find alternative ways to provide patient care.”

An explosion of temporary staffing

Travel nurses have been around for decades and became more widespread in the 1980s, as nursing shortages grew, but it’s really the pandemic that changed the landscape of the profession. In some healthcare settings, contract nurses are now almost as prevalent as staff nurses.

Jeffrey Tieman, president and CEO of Vermont Association of Hospitals and Health Systems (VAHHS), says that prior to COVID-19, his system used travel nurses “as a stop gap”; now he says they’re “in every department of the hospital every day of the week.” The same is true of Thomas Health, Kahn says. When she first became the hospital system’s chief nursing officer in 2019, the acute care team didn’t rely on traveling nurses at all; these days, about 40% of her acute care nurses are on temporary contracts.

The financial fallout of this trend for hospitals’ and nursing homes is staggering. Due largely to the increase in contract nurses, Thomas Health is now roughly 100% over its previous staffing budget, the hospital system tells TIME. Between Fiscal Years 2020 and 2021, VAHHS’s outlay for contract nurses increased $29 million, or 35%, the group says. “As the pandemic picked up and dragged on, the need for nurses intensified when the supply of nurses diminished,” Tieman says.

Depending on contract nurses also creates logistical problems, says Deb Snell, a registered nurse and the president of the Vermont

Federation of Nurses & Health Professionals. “It is difficult when you have new people coming in every 12-13 weeks, and orienting them to your floor, making sure they know where equipment is, where meds are, who to call for a problem,” she says. “It’s constant turnover.”

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Struggling to fill empty roles and way over budget on staffing, VAHHS reached out to Vermont Congressman Peter Welch for help coming up with a solution, and on Jan. 24, Welch and Morgan Griffith of Virginia wrote a letter to the White House, cosigned by nearly 200 other members of Congress. The letter urges the Biden Administration to investigate the extent to which contract nursing agencies are exploiting the pandemic to drive their profits by engaging in anticompetitive activity. “We are writing because of our concerns that certain nurse-staffing agencies are taking advantage of these difficult circumstances to increase their profits at the expense of patients and the hospitals that treat them,” the letter says.

Days later, the American Hospital Association and the American Health Care Association/National Center for Assisted Living, the major nursing home trade group, threw their support behind Welch and Griffith, calling on the Administration to help prevent the travel agencies “from exploiting our organizations’ desperate need for health care personnel.”

Travel nurses, meanwhile, were incensed. On social media and message boards, they begged supporters to call their members of Congress to defend them and their pay schedules. “Wait, what? They want to cap travel nurse pay but they won’t cap CEO and executive pay? Well… I guess they know who their true masters are, and it sure as hell ain’t the voters,” wrote one Reddit user.

“It’s just because they can get away with it”

Welch says capping contract nurses’ take-home pay was never the intention of his letter. “I never have and never would propose a cap on nursing pay,” he says. “Nurses are the frontline, and they’re overworked, they’re underpaid, and they legitimately point out how the executives get fat salaries while they have to do all this work.”

Instead, he says, one big reason for the financial burden on hospitals is the fees that nurse staffing agencies charge to assign travel nurses to health care settings that need them. Proculent Health, the workforce management tool used by healthcare companies, estimates that hospitals and other healthcare facilities are billed an additional 28% to 32% above the wages the agencies pay contract nurses.

Welch argues these agencies may be exploiting the pandemic’s circumstances at the expense of hospitals, health centers, and the patients who seek care at them. “The fee that the agency charges is not related to any additional work they do, or any value added,” Welch tells TIME. “It’s just because they can get away with it.”

AMN Healthcare Services reported its gross profits were $434 million in the fourth quarter of 2021, up 109% from a year prior,

according to an annual earnings report. Its net income, which takes into account all business related expenses and taxes it had to pay, was $116 million, an 1100% increase. Another healthcare staffing agency, Cross Country Healthcare, saw its revenue increase 93% between the third quarters of 2020 and 2021. It also reached $1 billion in annual revenue for the first time in the company's history in 2021.

In recent months, private equity firms have begun acquiring contract healthcare staff agencies at a rapid clip, signaling to Welch that investors believe there is even more money to be made off the travel nurse industry in years to come—which would put hospitals under even greater strain. One of the largest healthcare staffing agencies, Medical Solutions, was purchased by two private investment firms in August. Favorite Healthcare, another large staffing group, was bought by a private equity-owned staffing firm in January.

"Three of the 10 largest staffing agencies—and probably more—were purchased by private equity right around the time that the pandemic began," Welch says.

Staffing agencies argue that the higher prices health care facilities are paying are driven primarily by the higher wages the agencies pay nurses to meet the demand. In 2020, 75% of revenue nurse staffing agencies made went to wages and the costs of employing nurses, including payroll taxes, worker's compensation and unemployment insurance payments, and other benefits, says Toby Malara, vice president of government relations for the American Staffing Association (ASA), a trade group for the staffing industry. He adds that most of the association's nurse staffing agencies have seen their profits remain "relatively stable" during the pandemic.

Nurses worry about pay cuts — for good reason

Many nurses are worried that heightened government scrutiny will result in lower take-home pay for them — and that anxiety is not necessarily unfounded. Some states already cap nurse pay under certain situations, or are considering legislative action to do so. Minnesota, for example, caps contract nurses who work in nursing homes. The most that an RN can earn per hour during non-holidays is $62.36, according to documentation provided by the state's Department of Health. Massachusetts caps pay for RNs at hospitals around $120 per hour. At nursing home facilities, the state caps an RN's pay around $79 per hour, the state's Executive Office of Health and Human Services says.

Other states including Kansas, Ohio, Oregon, Illinois and Pennsylvania are now considering legislation to cap nurse pay in some cases. Pennsylvania state Rep. Timothy Bonner has introduced a bill to establish maximum rates for employees of travel nursing agencies in his state that would be no higher than 150% of the average statewide pay rate for similar jobs. "[Staffing] agencies have seized on the pandemic and the critical need for workers," he wrote in a letter to his statehouse colleagues, according to the Lewistown *Sentinel*, "and have raised their hourly rates to 100 percent, 200 percent or even 400 percent above the current median wage rate."

The White House referred TIME's questions about how regulatory action against the contract nursing industry would work to the Federal Trade Commission, which did not return a request for comment.

Many nurses say arbitrary pay caps are unfair. The problem is not high pay, they say; it is that there aren't enough nurses to do an increasingly challenging job for relatively low wages. And while the pandemic exacerbated nurse shortages nationwide, the problem long preceded COVID-19's added pressures. "Things were already getting tight even prior to the pandemic," says Snell in Vermont.

“Nurses have known and seen this coming for a while. We just couldn’t get people to listen.”

Part of the issue is demographics. The median age of RNs in 2020 was 52, according to a recent survey from the National Council of State Boards of Nursing, and with baby boomers retiring, more nurses will need replacing. But there’s no lack of interest. Enrollment in baccalaureate and higher-degree nursing programs increased in 2020, according to the American Association of Colleges of Nursing, and nurse practitioner graduates have swelled in recent years too. Nursing schools could be training even more graduates, experts say, but the cost of nursing school can be a barrier for students, and schools are also experiencing a shortage of nursing instructors.

But the largest factor, according to nurses unions and professional groups, is how low the pay is compared to how difficult the work environment is. “There is no nursing shortage in the United States. There is a shortage of nurses who are willing to work in these conditions,” says Michelle Mahon, a registered nurse who is assistant director of nursing practice at National Nurses United (NNU), the largest nurses union in the country. “This is something that’s been created by health care employers over a very long period of time.”

NNU has frequently criticized hospitals for adopting what it says are policies of chronic understaffing in order to help their bottom line. High patient-to-nurse ratios deteriorated patient care and put nurses at increased risk of workplace injuries and infections before COVID-19, Mahon says. Then when the pandemic swept in, hospitals that had prioritized cutting costs were unprepared.

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Health care doesn’t operate like a free market

While some nurse unions have been able to demand raises from large hospital systems during the pandemic, health facilities that see primarily patients who have government health insurance are often more limited in what they can pay. Nursing homes are overwhelmingly paid by Medicaid and Medicare, so they say the rates they can pay nursing staff are largely determined by how much the government programs reimburse per patient, and hospitals in low-income areas can face similar situations.

About 70% of the costs of operating a nursing home are related to labor, according to Clif Porter, senior vice president of government relations at AHCA/NCAL. But even as facilities have had to pay two to three times normal wages to hire temporary nurses during the pandemic, their reimbursement rates have not kept pace. “I can’t pass on inflation to my customer,” he says. “This creates a situation where our expenses exceed our revenue. It’s just that simple. And that’s just not sustainable.”

Porter says that he doesn’t want maximums for what nurses can make, but floats the idea of a cap on agency profits or regulations that stipulate how much of what a staffing agency charges it must pass on to its workers.

“If the legislation were to directly impact the [agency] overhead, we don’t believe that nurses salaries would be impacted,” says Ernest Grant, president of the American Nurses Association. But the ANA does not support any effort to lower nurse wages, and Grant added that the concern over price gouging has “become quite a distraction.”

Mahon agrees, saying the idea of investigating these staffing agencies will not solve the staffing crisis. Even if the health care facilities are not happy about the rates these staffing agencies are charging, she notes, they have found the money to pay them. “If there was serious reflection and introspection and desire to solve

[the nursing shortage], it would be focused inward by this industry," Mahon says.

More nurses, better treatment

Nurses groups' say there are other solutions that could retain and attract a larger workforce. NNU would like to see minimum staffing ratios, enhanced workplace safety measures, and increased funding for nursing education, for example. The ANA has also promoted ideas including improving nurse hours and mental health support, adjusting the Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services payment methods, and removing barriers that make it difficult for nurses to practice. "We really need to address it once and for all, and not just cap it off at this particular time," Grant says.

Desperate to retain staff, Thomas Health, where Jennie Kahn works, has increased bonus pay, instituted recruitment bonuses, expanded its tuition repayment programs and started offering its staff free meals at hospital cafeterias.

The University of Vermont Medical Center, meanwhile, just agreed to raise its nurse's wages by 20% over two years, with 10% being implemented now and an additional 5% coming in October 2022 and an additional 5% coming in October 2023.

Though Snell says the raises are a positive step toward retaining staff, she's not certain it is sufficient to stop the bleeding. A study released in October by the American Nurses Foundation reports 21% of nurses nationwide said they planned to resign from their jobs within the next six months. Another 29% said they were considering leaving. University of Vermont Medical Center is not immune.

"We have a lot of nurses leaving our hospital to go travel," she says. "I'm hoping the 10% right now will be enough to maybe keep some of them in place."

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COVID-19 Killed My Grandfather. But My Dad Was Too Busy Treating COVID-19 Patients to Grieve Him

Tara Law is a reporter at TIME. She works on the accolades team, where she helps lead long-term projects, including TIME100 Next, TIME100 Companies and TIME100 Inventions. She has also covered topics ranging from the COVID-19 pandemic, to the drug overdose epidemic, to Russia's invasion of Ukraine.

In early February, I got the call I'd dreaded for months: my 82-year-old grandfather, Charlie Law, had died. I'd tried to prepare myself as best as I could; Grandpa had Parkinson's disease and dementia, and he had been in physical and mental decline for about four years. Still, I hadn't seen my grandparents in person for two of those years because of the pandemic.

Once the initial waves of shock and sadness had washed over me, I was surprised to find I was angry. Losing my grandfather was inevitable, but it felt as if the disease that finally took his life—COVID-19—was not. Although my grandfather was vaccinated

and boosted, his dementia had confined him to a nursing home, which meant that he was at the mercy of the assisted living facility and the surrounding community to protect him from the virus. While I'd accepted that my grandpa didn't have long to live, and I knew that he was suffering, I'd hoped (naively, maybe) that he'd slip away in his sleep. COVID-19 had robbed him of even that.

Shortly after Grandpa passed, I asked my dad, Dr. Kevin Law—a doctor specializing in pulmonology and critical care at Robert Wood Johnson University Hospital Hamilton in New Jersey—about how he is coping with losing his father to COVID-19. He has helped lead his hospital's response to the pandemic through surge after surge for the last two years and has treated about 1,200 patients with COVID-19 at the hospital.

Grandpa getting COVID and suffering was the thing I was hoping wouldn't happen.

KEVIN LAW: I had an educated guess that he was going to get a life-threatening infection this winter: either a urinary tract infection, pneumonia, or COVID. I wasn't there, but I really don't think he suffered. Maybe that's my mind playing tricks on me, but I've seen patients like this. When they're very infirm, they become unconscious and go quickly.

I know my mom had some anger about it and felt like he hadn't been protected at the nursing home. But I'd like to think that the institution did its due diligence to protect the patient. Unfortunately, this latest iteration of COVID is very infectious. If you're susceptible, I don't think there's any escaping it, whether you're out in public or in an institution.

Has being on the front lines of the pandemic made it harder for you to cope with Grandpa's decline?

KL: I don’t think I was as present for my parents as I would have been ordinarily, and that that was frustrating. I’m very busy, they’re in another part of the country, and at times it’s been risky to travel.

I was surprised that you worked on the day that Grandpa passed. lt must have been hard for you.

KL: For your own mental health, you have to learn how to separate work, play, and personal life. I compartmentalize. You have to be able to do your job. You learn over time—as hard as it is, sometimes—to not let it interfere with your professional functioning. If I did, it would be very difficult to function.

A lot of people said I should have taken the day off, I should have taken a week off. I certainly contemplated that, but it would have just been way too much for the people I work with. They would have been overwhelmed.

I have pretty complicated feelings about the circumstances of Grandpa’s death, because like you, I expected he would pass anyway. But it just feels bad that people didn’t try harder to stop the virus from spreading.

KL: Over time, I learned not to waste a lot of energy on people’s behavior that I can’t change. I try to work on it with individuals, and I do get frustrated at times, dealing with individuals that don’t have a good explanation for why they’re not getting vaccinated. The fact that some people are going to be resistant to it is just human nature, and there’s nothing I can do to change that.

I do see people who, even though they’re not doing well, are still happy with their decision that they weren’t vaccinated, which is a remarkable thing to me. Or they’re willing to accept their fate, such as it is.

How have patients been treating you recently at this point in the pandemic?

KL: I see a lot of impatience. I see a general lack of understanding. I don't think they have as much empathy for us when we're fatigued or working hard or late or running behind. I think people were very sympathetic at first, and I don't think they are anymore.

They have to understand that a lot of us are still in that same position. We're still working much harder than we normally would. Even though most of us are vaccinated, we're still putting our livelihoods and our health at risk. We're really still working for the public and individuals. If they have some anger or frustration over this whole thing, it shouldn't be targeting medical workers.

How do you deal with your own anger at people for not getting vaccinated? How do you take care of yourself?

KL: There are times when I have empathy fatigue: when I don't feel as empathetic as I would normally feel for a sick, infected patient if they're not vaccinated. I have plenty of empathy for people who did get vaccinated but got sick in spite of it.

Anger is a strong word. It's more frustration and the feeling of impotence over the situation at times. The time I most feel it is when we're very busy in the hospital. I've seen 30 hospitalized COVID patients in a single day, sometimes 35. It wears you down. Maybe my experience helps me to handle the pain of my dad's death a little better. And it helps minimize my anger and frustration.

I think that some of the anger that people have about the virus, and the restrictions that have been placed on them, are somehow transferred onto physicians, nursing staff, and hospital workers. When I feel like somebody is targeting me or displacing their anger, this is something that I can call upon to kind of defuse that

situation. I say, “Listen, I lost my dad to this as well. So on some level, I understand what you’re feeling.”

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It’s 2022 and People Are Still Confused That My Kids Have Their Mother’s Last Name

Hirsch is the author of Why We Never Talk About Sugar, a short-story collection. Her stories, essays and comics have appeared in Vox, the New York Times, the Nib and elsewhere

The woman from the Social Security office had a lot of questions. I dutifully answered them, using my shoulder to clamp the big hospital phone to my ear so I could use both hands to adjust my one-day-old son’s latch. She asked me my name, birthdate, place of birth, marital status, Social Security number. Then she asked me all of these same questions about my husband. Then she asked for the baby’s time and date of birth, his sex, and to carefully spell his first and middle names.

She did not ask me for his last name, despite the fact that my husband and I had different last names. Half-dazed and exhausted, I didn’t notice this until her tone went from business-casual to chirpy and congratulatory and I realized she was about to end the call.

“Wait!” I said. “I didn’t tell you the baby’s last name!”

“Oh, I have it,” she replied, and spelled out my husband’s last name.

“No, actually, it’s Hirsch. H-I-R-S-C-H,” I said, emphasizing the “c” as was my habit.

“I thought you said you were married.”

“I am,” I said.

She replied, “Then Baby gets Dad’s last name.”

Read More: *My Kids Can’t Get Vaccinated Yet, and I’m Barely Keeping It Together*

This is the assumption I’ve been pushing back against since my first son was born nine years ago: that babies must take their fathers’ last name. It’s true that patrilineal baby-naming dominates in America. Researchers have found that heterosexual married couples give the baby the father’s name more than 95% of the time. But tradition wasn’t a good enough reason to convince me that the children I grew in my own body shouldn’t have my name. After all, it’s (mostly) women who do the hard work of pregnancy and childbirth. We also do the vast majority of the actual parenting (in the American Time Use Survey, mothers record spending more than twice as much time physically caring for young children as fathers). So why shouldn’t we pass on our names as well?

Luckily, my kids’ father agreed. We considered hyphenating, but that seemed like a one-generation solution before the number of names became unwieldy. Besides, he was never a fan of his last name, which was stamped onto his family’s documents on Ellis Island, and not the name they actually boarded the boat with, whereas my name was very important to me.

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My paternal grandfather, John Hirsch, had traced our genealogy back to the 1600s in Germany and Sweden. Some of my earliest memories are of sitting on the floor of his study, paging through the big binders of horizontally laid family trees. I loved looking at the names of my ancestors: Florence Mae, Winifred Alleyne, Henning Joseph. My great-grandmother was a descendant of Johnny Appleseed's half-brother. We were also connected to the Edwards family, descendants of a Welsh pirate and, arguably, the owners of a few dozen acres of land in lower Manhattan they would certainly never get back.

This didn't feel like history to me. It felt like who I was, who I am, and an important part of what I wanted to pass on to my children, and their children, and so on. I grew up in a family with three daughters, so if the name was going to survive another generation, one of us girls would have to buck tradition. I wanted it to be me.

I finally managed to persuade the lady from the Social Security office to record "Hirsch" as the baby's last name and, no, she didn't need to talk to my husband first. But this was just the first of many exchanges that have reminded me that a woman passing on her name demands an explanation, while a man doing the same does not.

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Most often, this looks like benign confusion. People see my kids' names and call their dad "Mr. Hirsch." I get asked for my birth name and then get strange looks when I reply, "Hirsch." For years, I got invitations and holiday cards addressed to "The HisLastName Family," even though 75% of the people in my home were Hirsches. Or people just want to know *why* the kids have my last

name and not their father's (a question I'd guess men who pass on their names never have to answer). I know people make assumptions based on what they're used to, but sometimes the comments reflect not just surprise but an underlying belief that the man is, by definition, the most important person in the family. People say things like, "You're lucky the father let you do that," as if I wouldn't be an equal partner in the decision.

And of course people online have *very* strong feelings about how I've chosen to name my children. Despite the fact that my kids' names have nothing to do with them and affect them in no way, dozens of people (mostly men) have taken time to share their outrage with me, call me names, accuse me of being a bad mother or of destroying incentives for men to marry, and threaten me for denying a man of his birthright to pass on his name. I've seen so many variations of people asking, "Why would you give the kids your father's last name instead of your husband's?" that, at times, I begun to feel invisible. It's not just my father's name. It's *my* name. Couldn't they see that erasing a woman's ownership of her own name is a symptom of the same disease I'm trying to remedy?

This devaluation of mothers doesn't exist only online. Mothers who work full time make an average of 75 cents for every dollar working fathers make. And in the early months of the pandemic, a Lerner Center for Public Health Promotion survey showed that 80% of U.S. adults who were not working due to caregiving responsibilities for kids not in school or daycare were women. Attempts to pass more social supports for working parents, like paid family and medical leave, subsidized daycare and universal preschool, have stalled, and it's mothers who will be shouldering the bulk of these burdens, giving up our jobs along with our names.

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I think of these facts every time someone asks, out of curiosity or anger, why my children have my name, but every time I hear my children's names spoken aloud or I write them down on one of the endless forms that materialize when you become a parent, I feel proud that their name is my name. My grandfather died before my first son was born but lived long enough to hear that I was expecting and that the baby would be a Hirsch, like him. Like me. It makes me happy to know that the name will live on, like the genealogy books that are now in my father's study and will someday be in mine and then my sons'.

And perhaps the name will go on after them as well, if they choose to have children of their own. Unless, of course, they opt to give their children their partners' names, a decision I would fully support. That's another thing I would be proud to pass on.

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The New Batman Is Deeply Unsettling. The Director Says That's the Point

Eliana Dockterman is a correspondent at TIME. She covers culture, society, and gender, including topics from blockbuster movies to the #MeToo movement to how the pandemic pushed moms out of the workplace.

Early in *The Batman*, our hero strides into a train station where a group of face-painted hooligans are harassing a citizen of Gotham. He starts punching their ringleader. Maybe too many times. And a little too hard. Is he enjoying it? The man Batman has saved doesn't say thank you. Instead, he crawls backward, begging for his life. Batman strikes fear in the hearts of villains, but he strikes fear in the hearts of victims, too.

"I wanted to play on this idea that Batman is going to unleash on these guys, and there's a part of you that can't wait to see it," says director Matt Reeves, whose superhero reboot hits theaters March 4. "You go to a Batman movie to see that moment. And then you see it's having a toxic effect. It makes you get a little unsettled."

The Batman, starring Robert Pattinson, isn't exactly a horror film, but it revels in discomfiting its audience. Though Reeves started working on the script with Peter Craig in 2017, it manages to capture our current feelings of despair and isolation—a sign that the discontent that permeates the movie has been brewing for a while. Christopher Nolan's Dark Knight trilogy told the story of a superhero desperate to help his city eradicate corruption so that it would no longer need someone to watch over it. Reeves' version knows a bright future is not possible. That's an apt, if grim, observation at a time when a pandemic, increased anxiety about global warming, and a war in Europe have contributed to a pervasive sense of doom.

In superhero films, the line between good and evil is usually bright. Reeves' new film is cloaked in realism and a moral muddiness that echoes thrillers like *Se7en* and neo-noirs like *Chinatown.* Batman is hunting a serial killer called the Riddler. Played by Paul Dano, he's a far cry from Jim Carrey's green-suited slapstick character from 1995's *Batman Forever.* Dano's Riddler hides behind an army-green mask and leaves puzzles for the Caped Crusader on mutilated corpses. Like Batman, he targets Gotham's corrupt politicians and gangsters. Unlike Batman, he's willing to kill, and—no less frightening—has leveraged social media to amass a violent, fringe following. "The far-out parts of internet culture, I found that scary," says Dano. "The film is more terrifying because of its contact with reality."

Reeves, whose previous work includes the monster movie *Cloverfield* and installments in the *Planet of the Apes* franchise, aims to bring a humanist perspective to genre filmmaking. And in *The Batman*, Reeves empathizes with his villain and criticizes his hero. Superhero movies "can be a reductive, iconic genre," he says. "I wanted to create a movie with shades of gray."

Read the Review: *The Batman* Is Dark, Real Dark—Or So It Wants Us to Think

The Batman Is Dark, Real Dark—Or So It Wants Us to Think

Pattinson is our eighth live-action Batman on the silver screen, and a far cry from the whiz-bang-pow TV version from the 1960s. Tim Burton's film adaptations were dark, but not grim. It was Nolan who set the stage for nearly two decades of dark DC Comics films, drawing heavily from somber comic books with story lines about psychological torture. If Warner Bros. briefly strayed from the Nolan playbook by hiring Marvel Studios veteran Joss Whedon to punch up the dialogue in *Justice League*, *The Batman* swings back toward grit.

Inevitably, critics will compare *The Batman* to Nolan's films. But Reeves distinguishes his vision from what came before. This moody, atmospheric movie is uninterested in Batman's gadgets, and the car-chase scene, while terrific, is purposefully grounded: the Batmobile weaves down a crowded highway, rather than taking flight. The film cracks only a few jokes, mostly at Batman's expense.

Christian Bale excelled at playing Batman's two sides: the charming, if smarmy, Bruce Wayne (harkening to his *American Psycho* days) and the brooding bat. Reeves asks Pattinson to play to *his* own strengths. This Bruce has no playboy alter ego and would prefer to stay home and journal. When he is obliged to leave his manse without a mask, the erstwhile *Twilight* star sulks beneath his bangs. And Reeves spares viewers another scene of Bruce's parents' death, instead alluding to a tragic past through his mournful glances at rich boys toddling around Gotham.

His Batman is also not as confident: early in the film, Bruce admits he's been patrolling the streets of Gotham for two years to keep the city safe, and if anything, crime has gotten worse, not better. His decision to strike fear into his enemies by dressing up as a bat, may, in fact, be inspiring villains to don masks of their own and terrorize the public. "Most films start as an origin story. He loses his parents in this violent way. He masters himself, and then dedicates himself to this mission," says Reeves. "I wanted him to be human and flailing and struggling."

Dano's Riddler is a villain in the thrall of the crimefighter. "There can be no Riddler without the Batman," says Dano. Reeves recommended Dano read *Mindhunter,* about the first FBI team to hunt serial killers. (The actor had to take the book to coffee shops to read so he didn't have to keep it by his bedside: "I get squeamish.")

Many of Batman's most iconic nemeses have been scene stealers. Heath Ledger and Joaquin Phoenix won Oscars with their respective turns as the Joker. Tom Hardy's hulking figure and muffled voice as Bane defines *The Dark Knight Rises*—for better or worse. The Riddler, by contrast, is a specter: he doesn't show his face for most of the film. And when he does, he's a human with a reason for his anger and a meticulous moral code.

Every character in Reeves' film has a backstory, usually a tragic one. And Reeves seems much more interested in the systemic issues that created Gotham's many villains than his predecessors ever were. For instance, Gotham is littered with orphans, including Selina Kyle (Zoë Kravitz), also known as Catwoman. Unlike all the other abandoned children in Gotham, Bruce Wayne was raised by a loving butler in a mansion. Nolan briefly alludes to Batman's privilege in *The Dark Knight* with a telling crack about a Batman imitator wearing "hockey pads" instead of Kevlar. And *Justice League* largely ignores Batman's wealth.

But in *The Batman*, Selina calls out Bruce on his myopic view of Gotham afforded by his status as a white man and the comfort of his inheritance. "He's completely sheltered and has this moral superiority," Reeves says. "He encounters her in the underworld and assumes she's morally corrupt. And he's entirely wrong about her because he didn't have to struggle."

Reeves' Gotham is notably more diverse than past iterations, and as a Black woman, Selina's challenge to Bruce carries greater weight. Reeves doesn't hit you over the head with this commentary but quietly shows how the characters' backgrounds might affect their relationships. This movie is, at its heart, a love story about two people from different worlds trying to learn to trust each other—even as we, the audience, can't decide whether either should be trusted.

For a movie called *The Batman*, the film offers a number of different perspectives. In the very first scene, Reeves plays with the camera's point of view: we see a rich family in their home, shot through binoculars. Who is spying on this family? Is it someone plotting to kill the Wayne family in the past? Is it Batman watching a corrupt Gotham politician in the present? Is the Riddler targeting a victim? Reeves deploys the ambiguous shot again later in the film, this time trained on Selina alone in her apartment. Watching her feels like a violation. "I loved this Hitchcockian point-of-view storytelling where you use the camera to implicate the viewer," says Reeves. "The viewer is now the voyeur."

These aren't just tricks of the camera. Reeves has a bigger question on his mind: If Batman stalks the city calling himself "Vengeance," what really differentiates him from the vengeful villains he's

hunting down? The morality of Nolan's Batman was never in question—only whether Gotham perceived him as a do-gooder or a madman. But this Batman has to make the decision to be good.

Because of their popularity and the potency of their symbolism, superhero movies tend to get flattened, and misinterpreted in the process. Ledger's Joker, who has a truly frightening agenda, has been boiled down an image and a caption: "Some men just want to watch the world burn." A Marvel joke—"Thanos was right"—devolves from a radical take on environmentalism to an ironic quote on a coffee mug.

Batman is particularly vulnerable to this type of simplification. In the comics, he's been a pure hero and a borderline villain. "There's a version of glorifying a kind of brutality of Batman that's fascist," says Reeves. "You could see that meme. And then there are other portrayals where you could see that he's struggling in this very human way." By constantly changing perspective and forcing us to consider Batman's exploits from different points of view, Reeves insists on a more complicated protagonist who has to reflect on what, exactly, he wants to symbolize: fear or hope. "I wanted him to be forced to have an awakening," he says, "and confront what he's doing."

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You’re Wrong About Host Sarah Marshall Was Always Fascinated by History’s Misunderstood Women. Now the Rest of Us Are Too

Eliana Dockterman is a correspondent at TIME. She covers culture, society, and gender, including topics from blockbuster movies to the #MeToo movement to how the pandemic pushed moms out of the workplace.

Sarah Marshall fell hard for Tonya Harding. “Why do you fall in love with the people you fall in love with?” Marshall asks. “If you research people for a living, you can ask the same question about why you dedicate months or years of your life to a particular human being and trying to understand them.” These days, Marshall is best known as the host of the popular podcast *You’re Wrong About*, in which she sets out to debunk misremembered history. But from 2010 to 2014, Marshall was obsessively reading the tabloid coverage of the disgraced figure skater who was accused of conspiring with her ex-husband Jeff Gillooly to attack Nancy Kerrigan, her rival in the 1994 Olympics. (Harding pleaded guilty

to hindering the prosecution but denied being involved in the planning.)

In 2014, Marshall collected her thoughts in a 11,000-plus-word essay for *The Believer*, defending a woman who would become one of her future podcast subjects. She argued that the media vilified Harding for being poor in a sport made for the rich, being a victim of abuse who didn't leave her abuser, and being athletic at a time when skating valued grace over power. Stories always seemed to slip in the fact that Harding had divorced and then reconciled with Gillooly. "Despite the restraining order and 911 calls she placed, and despite her claims that she feared for her life," Marshall wrote, "few phrases … were quite so gleefully suggestive as *white trash lifestyle*, as *live-in ex-husband*."

"We can debate the extent of the foreknowledge she had," Marshall says now. "But I think, really, we were punishing her for the crime of being trashy."

This was before Margot Robbie starred in the sympathetic Harding biopic *I, Tonya*, and brought Harding as her date to the 2018 Golden Globes. While we're inundated these days by documentaries, podcasts, and essays about women who made tabloid headlines in the '90s and '00s that add context to elucidate how we unfairly maligned them, Marshall was at the forefront of this trend before many people even recognized its value. "People

had been talking about this for a long time, but maybe in quieter corners of the media," says Carolyn Chernoff, a sociologist who studies gender in pop culture. "I do think that Sarah Marshall had this idea before other people really were talking about it in a mainstream way. We need to look at those stories to figure out what we're doing wrong as a society, and do a little bit better."

Marshall's essay went viral among the media set. It caught the attention of Michael Hobbes, who was working at a human rights organization but would soon join the Huffington Post as a reporter, and he wrote Marshall an anonymous fan letter. Years later, he wrote to her again, attaching his name this time, to ask if she wanted to collaborate on a podcast about misunderstood history.

You're Wrong About debuted in May 2018 and exploded in the early months of the pandemic. Though podcast downloads briefly dipped overall during that time, interest in comedy and education podcasts remained relatively stable, likely because people either sought funny distractions or—at least initially—saw quarantine as a time to better themselves, whether that meant baking bread, watching newly free Shakespeare performances online, or delving into the archives of history podcasts. *You're Wrong About* happens to be both educational and hilarious. Every episode, one of the hosts would play storyteller, the other vocal listener, gasping at revelations and offering up wry commentary. Occasionally guests with deep expertise on a topic would join them as well.

The podcast functions as a history lesson, a media critique, and a meditation on the ephemeral nature of truth. "I often try to reclaim a story that the tabloids have found lucrative because they present someone who the public can safely mock," Marshall, 33, says during a Zoom call from her home-slash-podcasting studio in Portland, Ore. "Something powerful happens when I am able to look at someone's life and the surprising things they did and say, 'Oh yeah, I could see how I could do that.'"

You're Wrong About, often the No. 1 history podcast in iTunes' rankings, now garners 3.25 million to 4 million downloads a month, and tends to sit in the top 100 podcasts overall. The show relies on tried-and-true podcasting tropes: many of the episodes deal with true crime; the show capitalizes on our obsession with nostalgia; and the colloquial nature of the conversations makes it feel more like a debate at a bar than a history lecture. On Feb. 3, it won the iHeartMedia award for Podcast of the Year, beating out massive hits like *The Daily*, *Conan O'Brien Needs a Friend*, and *Crime Junkie*.

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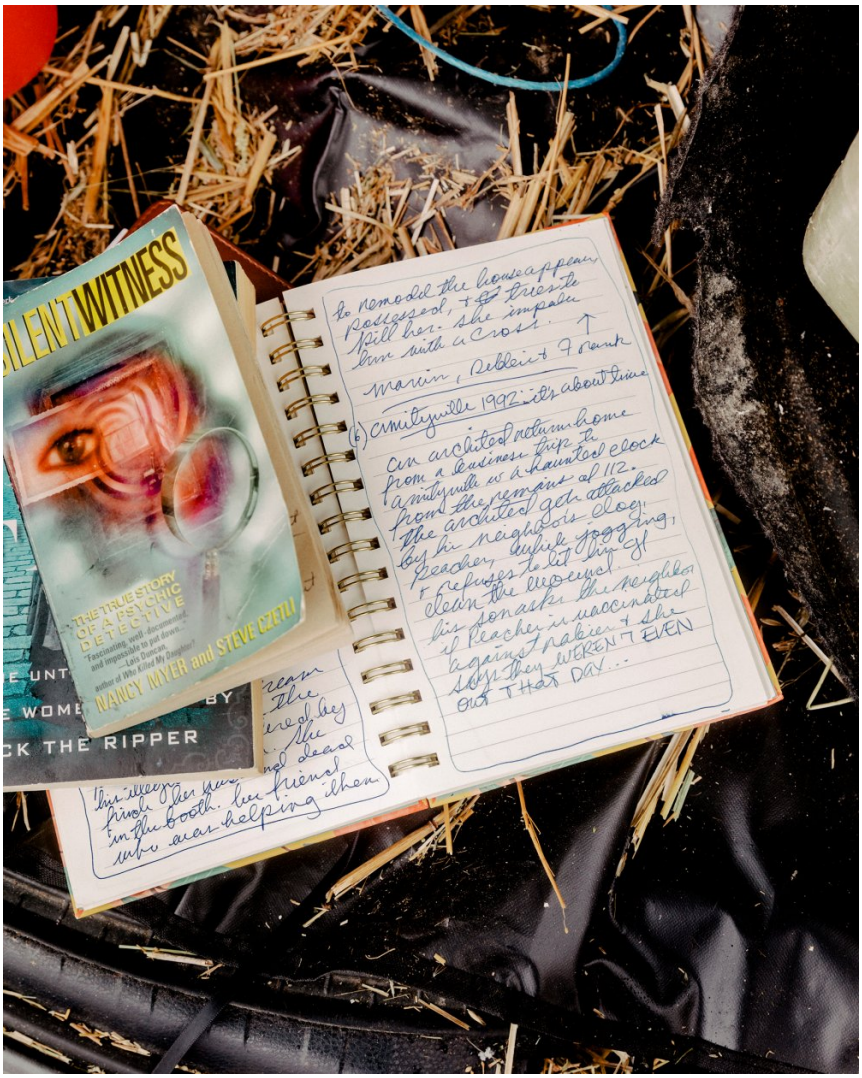
Unlike most of the shows that surround it on the charts, *You're Wrong About* is not produced by an established news outlet or major podcast network, even as companies like Spotify gobble up shows; according to Edison Research, it was one of only four independent podcasts in the top 50 in the third quarter of 2021. It has never even run an ad. The hosts have rejected all offers to be bought out. Instead, the show subsists on product sales, donations, and a subscription service for bonus episodes through Patreon. Among the merchandise is a sweatshirt printed with "It was capitalism all along." Another lists several of the maligned women whom the show has asked listeners to reconsider: "Monica & Janet & Tonya & Anna Nicole."

These days Marshall is hosting the show on her own. Despite their success, Hobbes left in October 2021, citing burnout, to concentrate on his other podcast, *Maintenance Phase*, on which he and a co-host debunk the junk science behind wellness fads. (Marshall also co-hosts the *You Are Good* podcast about movies.) At times the hosts were producing two episodes of *You're Wrong About* per week, and last year, they both felt they were running out of insight.

Marshall considered departing too, but ultimately decided to stay. The pandemic had made her more cynical, she realized, and as she tries to find the voice of the show without Hobbes, she wants to get back in touch with the empathy that she has extended to everyone from Jessica Simpson to O.J. Simpson: “I need to start believing in people again.”



Like Harding, Marshall grew up in Oregon. She describes herself as a “lonely, indoor kid” who watched a lot of cable TV. Her media diet included shows like VH1’s *I Love the ’90s*, a series that revisited pop-culture phenomena with snark rather than rigor. The thesis, Marshall recalls, tended to boil down to “‘Look at this stupid bitch who wanted America’s media to abuse her,’ so we did.”

A voracious reader with a penchant for falling down research rabbit holes, Marshall also obsessed over everything creepy and crime-related, particularly scary stories that centered on women, from *Rosemary's Baby* to true-crime TV shows. She still occasionally falls asleep to a TV narrator describing how the victim of the week was murdered, though she now has a complicated relationship with the often-exploitative genre.

As a graduate student in creative writing at Portland State University, Marshall began to study women's captivity narratives in colonial America. She theorized that myths of young girls being possessed by demons were a manifestation of early panic about the increasing independence of women. She began to realize how the cultural and political forces of any era help shape these narratives in newspapers and novels. After graduation, she spent years pitching essays like the one about Harding, but with limited success. One on Anna Nicole Smith earned some attention, but she had trouble convincing editors that these stories needed to be told. "I'd be like, 'Let's revisit Amy Fisher,' and an editor would be like, 'Why?'"

Hobbes' podcast conceit offered an outlet for those stories. The two would comb through publicly available documents like court records, biographies, and contemporaneous news coverage for the facts. And nothing pleased Marshall more than ordering pulpy true-crime books from eBay for episodes on the Satanic Panic or Nancy Grace. The co-hosts called into question the familiar stories of Kitty Genovese, a woman who was supposedly stabbed while 37 impassive New Yorkers looked on. (In fact, bystanders did call the police, and one risked her own life to rush to Genovese and cradle her head in her lap as she died.) And Jessica Hahn, who supposedly brought down an evangelist empire when she had an "affair" with Jim Bakker. (Hahn has said for years that Bakker and one of his colleagues raped her; they said the encounter was consensual.) And

Marie Antoinette, who supposedly said of starving peasants, “Let them eat cake.” (Nope.)

Marshall and Hobbes’ goal was not to unearth some hidden fact but to refocus the narrative on a particular person or issue. The multipart series on the 2002 D.C. snipers, for instance, made the case that while reporters at the time framed the story around terrorism, it was actually a tale of domestic abuse. The older of the two shooters, John Allen Muhammad, had emotionally manipulated, starved, and threatened his ex-wife Mildred Muhammad. He even kidnapped their children. Hobbes and Marshall argue on that evidence that John Allen’s real objective was to harm his ex-wife and her friends; he only orchestrated the murder of strangers to obscure his intention to target people he knew. The podcast spent an entire episode on Mildred’s journey to become an advocate for battered women.

But *You’re Wrong About* doesn’t just shine a light on victims and their untold stories. Marshall has also spent hours examining history’s villains with empathy so radical that a listener might wonder whether a subject is worthy of her understanding. She has recorded more episodes on the O.J. Simpson trial than on any other subject, and you can hear her exploring whether her seemingly limitless empathy does indeed have a limit: Is Simpson—who was acquitted of the murders of Nicole Brown Simpson and Ron Goldman but later wrote a book disturbingly titled *If I Did It: Confessions of the Killer*—telling some delusional version of his truth? Or is he a monster who defies comprehension? “I probably err a little bit too far on the side of being credulous and wanting to believe that people are at least trying to tell the truth—or *their* truth,” she says.

Marshall may have been ahead of the curve with her Harding essay, but by the time *You’re Wrong About* debuted, the country was in the midst of a major reckoning with sexism. In early 2017,

after Donald Trump's victory over Hillary Clinton, 4.6 million protesters across the U.S. turned out for the Women's March. #MeToo would go viral later that year. From 2016 to 2018, an HBO film on Anita Hill titled *Confirmation*, a Slate podcast called *Slow Burn* on Bill Clinton and Monica Lewinsky, and a Ryan Murphy series on the O.J. Simpson trial that focused heavily on the media's criticism of prosecutor Marcia Clark flooded the airwaves.

Throughout the '90s, the media pummeled women for the crime of being famous. We focused on their clothes, their hair, or the details of their sex lives, rather than the pain they endured, the power the men in their lives abused, or the work they were trying to do. While not every episode of *You're Wrong About* deals with sexism, it's a pervasive theme. "When we started the show," Marshall says, "I was really eager to share this observation I had that the American media blame women for whatever happens near them."

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The churn of reclaimed women's narratives has only intensified in the last year. Beanie Feldstein played Lewinsky in another Ryan Murphy show *Impeachment*, co-produced by Lewinsky herself. Both Emma Corrin and Kristen Stewart ventured inside the psyche of Princess Diana in *The Crown* and *Spencer*, respectively, each earning an Emmy or Oscar nod; Elizabeth Debicki will do the same later this year in another season of *The Crown*. Three high-profile Britney Spears documentaries shed light on the pop star's infamous "breakdown" and tacitly advocated for Spears to be released from her conservatorship. This year we've already gotten commiserative retellings of Pamela Anderson's sex-tape scandal in *Pam & Tommy,* Janet Jackson's Super Bowl performance in the documentary *Janet Jackson*, and the jailing of scammer Anna "Delvey" Sorokin in Shonda Rhimes' *Inventing Anna*.

When Jessica Chastain was preparing to produce and star in last year's *The Eyes of Tammy Faye*, she sent around the *You're Wrong About* episode on evangelist Tammy Faye Bakker (now Tammy Faye Messner) to everyone working on that film. Marshall recently rereleased that episode with a new intro featuring an interview with Chastain, who has since earned an Oscar nomination for the role. The actor praised the work Marshall did to rehab Messner's image.

"We're in the middle of this societal reckoning with history … especially around issues of gender and race and sexuality," Hobbes told Marshall on his last episode. "And I think your work has been a really big part of sparking that. When you wrote that Tonya Harding piece, when you wrote your Anna Nicole piece, the kinds of things that you were doing, at the time, nobody was doing them."

Today, Marshall admits that recording episodes without a partner can be daunting. "I feel like there are ways I could go that I haven't even thought of yet," she says. She wants the show to remain a conversation in which one person explains to another something they have researched or are passionate about. But she and Hobbes spent years getting into a rhythm with each other before the show hit it big, and now she has to find that energy with new people each week—though she hopes some guests will become regulars.

Marshall also struggles to reconcile the excitement she feels about the show's rapid growth during the pandemic with the exhaustion of living and working through it. "It's a stressful time, and it stresses me out to consistently have to have something meaningful to say to so many listeners," she says. Instead she's trying to focus on the joyful aspects of the show. "I prefer to think of myself as an entertainer. I do think I can be funny on a routine basis."

Fortunately for Marshall, her jokes tend to telegraph profound lessons—and reminders to persevere. To quote one particularly apt T-shirt sold on the *You're Wrong About* site: "If Marcia Clark could get through 1995, then I can get through this day."

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